

Mendel University in Brno

Faculty of Regional Development and International Studies

**The role of student movements in Thailand's pro-democracy protests
(2020–2021)**

Bachelor's thesis

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DECLARATION

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Acknowledgements

I would like to sincerely thank my supervisor, Dr. Martin Petlach, for his guidance and insightful comments throughout the writing of this thesis. I am also very grateful to my family for their patience, encouragement, and support, which made it possible for me to complete this thesis in a positive and motivating environment.

LIST OF ACRONYMS

FFP	Future Forward Party	Phak Anakhot Mai	พรรคอนาคตใหม่
FYM	Free Youth Movement	Yowachon Plot Aek	เยาวชนปลดแอก
MFP	Move Forward Party	Phak Kao Klai	พรรคก้าวไกล
NCPO	National Council for Peace and Order	Khana raksa khwam sangop haeng chat	คณะรักษาความสงบแห่งชาติ
NGOs	Non-Governmental Organizations	Ongkon phatthana ekachon	องค์กรพัฒนาเอกชน
POS	Political Opportunity Structure	Khrongsang okat thang kan mueang	โครงสร้างโอกาสทางการเมือง
PP	People’s Party	Phak Prachachon	พรรคประชาชน
RM	Resource Mobilization	Kan radom sapphayakon	การระดมทรัพยากร
SMT	Social Movement Theory	Thritsadi khabuan-kan thang sangkhom	ทฤษฎีขบวนการทางสังคม

ABSTRACT

In recent years, Thailand has experienced a renewed wave of youth-led political mobilization, particularly during the 2020–2021 pro-democracy protests, which challenged both the military-backed government and long-standing political taboos. This thesis examines the role of student movements in these protests, focusing on how they mobilized, formulated their demands, and interacted with the political environment. The theoretical part introduces key approaches of Social Movement Theory, including resource mobilization, political opportunity structures, and framing, and applies them to a Southeast Asian setting, while also outlining the political and social context of Thailand and briefly introducing the student movements to clarify their main features and significance. The analytical section builds on this foundation and examines the movements in greater depth, focusing on protest dynamics, governmental responses, and their broader political impacts. The results show that student movements mobilized through a combination of digital communication, decentralized coordination, and the use of culturally relatable symbols and references, supported by additional resources such as educational institutions, diverse skill sets, and small-scale funding. Their demands were articulated through coherent framing processes, which enabled them to connect with different social groups and broaden public debate. At the same time, the Thai government responded primarily through legal and repressive measures, including the use of emergency powers, legal prosecution, and restrictions on public assembly, without introducing any institutional reforms. Despite these constraints, the protest movements had impact on political discourse, contributed to increased political polarization, and influenced electoral politics, particularly in the 2023 general election.

Keywords: student movements, protests, Social Movement Theory, Thailand

ABSTRAKT

V posledních letech zažilo Thajsko novou vlnu studentské politické mobilizace, zejména během prodemokratických protestů v letech 2020–2021, které zpochybnily jak vládu s výraznou podporou armády, tak dlouhodobá politická tabu. Tato práce zkoumá roli studentských hnutí v těchto protestech se zaměřením na způsoby jejich mobilizace, formulaci požadavků a interakci s politickým prostředím. Teoretická část představuje klíčové přístupy teorie sociálních hnutí, včetně mobilizace zdrojů, struktur politických příležitostí a rámování, a aplikuje je na prostředí jihovýchodní Asie, zároveň také nastiňuje politický a sociální kontext Thajska a stručně představuje studentská hnutí za účelem objasnění jejich hlavních charakteristik a významu. Analytická část na tento základ navazuje a podrobněji zkoumá samotná hnutí se zaměřením na dynamiku protestů, reakce vlády a jejich širší politické dopady. Výsledky ukazují, že studentská hnutí mobilizovala prostřednictvím kombinace digitální komunikace, decentralizované koordinace a využívání kulturně srozumitelných symbolů a referencí, přičemž byla podpořena i dalšími zdroji, jako jsou vzdělávací instituce, rozmanité dovednosti účastníků a drobné finanční příspěvky. Jejich požadavky byly formulovány prostřednictvím koherentních rámovacích procesů, které jim umožnily oslovit různé sociální skupiny a rozšířit veřejnou debatu. Thajská vláda naopak reagovala především prostřednictvím právních a represivních opatření, včetně využití mimořádných pravomocí, trestního stíhání a omezení veřejného shromažďování, aniž by zavedla jakékoli institucionální reformy. Navzdory těmto omezením měla protestní hnutí výrazný dopad na politický diskurz, přispěla ke zvýšené politické polarizaci a ovlivnila volební politiku, zejména během parlamentních voleb v roce 2023.

Klíčová slova: studentská hnutí, protesty, teorie sociálních hnutí, Thajsko

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INTRODUCTION

Protest movements represent an important element in the political development of many countries. They frequently emerge as collective responses to injustice, restraints, or social inequality, and often succeed in reshaping political institutions and public discourse. Within this wider process, student movements play an important role. Students often experience fewer societal constraints than other groups and are therefore better able to act decisively on political issues (Altbach, 1970). Unlike workers, who typically face practical limitations such as the need for majority support before striking, students can mobilize even as a smaller group, for example by occupying university buildings, and still generate a significant political impact. They can organize quickly and use creative and flexible forms of protests that attract attention, which helps them play a more influential role in political movements (Barker, 2008).

In Thailand, student activism has contributed significantly throughout the 20th and 21st centuries, from the 1973 uprising that challenged military rule to following waves of mobilization demanding constitutional and political reforms (Anamwathana & Thanapornsanguth, 2023; Ganjanakhundee, 2021). Since becoming a constitutional monarchy in 1932, the country has experienced more than 22 coup attempts, of which 13 were successful (Chanlett-Avery, Dolven, & Smith, 2020). This political instability has led to repeated shifts between authoritarian rule and democratic reforms. In these shifts, students and young people have often had a major impact. Against this background, the pro-democracy protests of 2020–2021 stand out as one of the most significant movements in recent Thai history (Zhang, 2022). These protests were notable not only for their intensity and duration but also for the active involvement of the younger generation (Ockey, 2021). Thai students became the primary actors in articulating demands, framing narratives, and mobilizing supporters.

In particular, the dissolution of the opposition *Future Forward Party* (FFP) in early 2020, a reformist political party that challenged the military-backed government and called for democratic reforms, became a key trigger for the protest movements (Ockey, 2021). Its disbandment followed the widely criticized 2019 election, which the junta repeatedly delayed and conducted under the new 2017 constitution that empowered the appointed Senate to help choose the prime minister and introduced controversial rule changes that structurally favored the military (McCargo & Alexander, 2019). While *Future Forward* had attracted many young voters and emerged as a major opposition force, its dissolution, together with the widely viewed unfairness of the election, deepened public frustration and motivated many young people to take to the streets, starting flash-mob demonstrations organized largely through social media platforms (Ockey, 2021; Charoenthansakul & Natee, 2023). Twitter and Facebook became crucial tools for spreading information, expressing dissatisfaction, providing moral support, and calling for collective action (Charoenthansakul & Natee, 2023; Sinpeng, 2021). At the same time, conservative, pro-establishment royalist groups used the internet space to counter the

protests and support the traditional authority of the monarchy (Sombatpoonsiri, 2023). The demands of the protesters directly challenged the two most powerful political institutions in Thailand: the military-backed government and the monarchy. Protesters called for the resignation of Prime Minister Prayuth Chan-o-cha, the dissolution of parliament, and the amendment of the then constitution. Most importantly, they broke long-standing taboos by openly questioning the role of the monarchy and demanding limits on its political and economic influence (Ockey, 2021; Seo, 2021).

The growing intensity of the protests and the increasing support among the broader public caused anxiety among the ruling elites. Rather than engaging in dialogue and seeking compromise, the authorities resorted to repressive measures, further deepening tensions between demonstrators and the state. The escalation ended in violent crackdowns involving the use of tear gas, rubber bullets, and water cannons, resulting in injuries not only among protesters but also among members of the security forces (Seo, 2021; Charoenthansakul & Natee, 2023). While such repression temporarily reduced mobilization, it also drew greater attention to the movement, both domestically and internationally, and deepened debates within Thai society (ICJ, 2020).

The political impact of the protests continued despite state repression. *The Move Forward Party* (MFP), formed by former members of the dissolved FFP, won the most seats in the 2023 general election (Wongswangpanich, 2023). The party gained significant popularity, particularly among the younger generation, by aligning itself with anti-government movements and advocating for political reforms favored by student activists (Nethipo, Phon-Amnuai & Vongsayan, 2023). The MFP's victory showed that the issues raised during the 2020–2021 protests remained important to many voters. This was, however, only temporary because in 2024 the MFP was declared a threat to the constitutional monarchy and was officially dissolved. Shortly after, the party quickly re-emerged under a new name, the *Prachachon Party* (PP), which continues to exist today and remains committed to pursuing structural reforms in Thai politics. (Stiftung, 2024).

Research aim

In this thesis, I aim to map the role of student movements in Thailand's 2020–2021 pro-democracy protests, a period marked not only by renewed youth mobilization but also by an unusually open wave of public criticism directed toward both the military-backed government and the monarchy (Ockey, 2021). I will also place these movements in the context of Thailand's political system and public discourse and describe the key actors, main demands, and governmental responses. Using the framework of *Social Movement Theory* (SMT),¹ I will analyze the emergence and development of these movements, focusing on how they mobilized, articulated their goals, and challenged existing political

¹ The theoretical framework of Social Movement Theory, including the concepts of resource mobilization (1.1.1), political opportunity structure (1.1.2), and framing (1.1.3), which serve to analyze the movements' mobilization, demands, and political challenges, is detailed in chapter 1 (theoretical part).

structures. And finally, I will also reflect on how public dissatisfaction with the 2019 general election served as a trigger for the later student movements and map the 2023 election results to assess movements' long-term political impact.

I will expand on this topic because the 2020–2021 Thai student protests represent one of the first large-scale and highly digitally coordinated youth movements in Southeast Asia (Reynaldi, Dhiyaa & Imawan, 2023; Lee, 2021). Their enhanced ability to organize across campuses and online platforms marks a new phase of political engagement among young people in the region (Thomas, Beattie & Zhang, 2020). In this thesis, I will apply the framework of Social Movement Theory to analyze how youth activism operates under semi-authoritarian regimes and how it shapes political and social change. Furthermore, I will characterize how students and young people use digital media to mobilize support, express dissent, and redefine the boundaries of public discussion in a digitally constrained environment (Asia Centre, 2022).

To explore these themes, I will address the following research questions:

RQ1: *How did Thai student movements mobilize and formulate their demands during the 2020–2021 pro-democracy protests?*

RQ2: *What were the governmental responses to these movements?*

RQ3: *How were the student movements reflected in political discourse?*

Methods

To achieve my research aim and to enable an in-depth analysis of this complex political and social phenomenon, I will use a qualitative case study approach guided by the framework of *Social Movement Theory* (SMT). This specific theoretical choice is essential because the use of SMT helps explain how social movements mobilize resources, build support, and react to political opportunities. SMT also provides an integrated, multidimensional framework which offers a deeper explanation than single theories or inflexible analysis of movements (Chandler, 2005). According to Ugwu and Eze (2023) qualitative research is created to gather non-numerical data to produce insights. It is not statistical and is either semi-structured or unstructured. Specifically, I will use an interpretative case study (Lijphart, 1971), focusing on the single case of the 2020–2021 student movements. This approach is chosen because it enables me to apply an established theoretical framework (SMT) to this case rather than create new theory. This theoretically guided interpretation is important for my thesis because it allows for a detailed understanding of the movement's strategies and limits within the semi-authoritarian Thai context.

In the theoretical part of my thesis, specifically in chapter 1, I will outline the general framework of Social Movement Theory, defining key approaches that serve as the analytical categories for the entire thesis. In particular, I will focus on three core components of SMT extensively discussed by scholars such as Goodwin and Jasper (2015) and Benford and Snow (2000): framing, which examines how the movements articulated their demands; resource mobilization, which analyzes how the movements utilized digital, human, and organizational resources; and political opportunity structure, which addresses how the established political environment either enabled or constrained the protests. Defining these approaches clearly in the theoretical part is the essential initial step, allowing me to systematically categorize and interpret the data in the analytical section. To provide the necessary context for this case study, chapter 2 will include a brief contextual overview of Thailand's political system, major political developments before 2020, and the state of civil liberties and public discourse leading up to the protests. Understanding this political background is necessary because the emergence and durability of student activism cannot be fully analyzed without reference to the broader institutional and political environment in which these movements operated (Sripokangkul, Draper, Crumpton & Muangming, 2019). In chapter 3, I will also summarize the main events of the 2020–2021 pro-democracy protests, providing essential background for the later analysis. Including this overview within the theoretical part ensures that in the analytical section I can fully concentrate on the application of SMT.

I will proceed with a systematic analysis through qualitative analysis and the application of SMT categories to the Thai case (Hsieh & Shannon, 2005; Bingham, 2023). This means that I will systematically code the collected secondary data according to the concepts of political opportunities (Eisinger, 1973), resource mobilization (McCarthy & Zald, 1977), and framing processes (Goffman, 1974), as defined in the theoretical chapter. The data sources I will review include academic literature, reports and analyses from reputable international and Thai media outlets, documents from Non-Governmental Organizations (NGOs), and human rights watchdogs. The analytical coding will proceed by categorizing relevant parts relating to the use of specific hashtags and organizational resources under the resource mobilization category, and parts describing police actions and the institutional structure under the political opportunity structure category (Kriesi, 1991). Similarly, statements, narratives, and protest slogans along with the movement's key demands will be tracked within the framing processes category. Finally, I will evaluate how the student movements were reflected in political discourse and society. This will involve synthesizing the findings from the SMT categories² and comparing them with observable outcomes, such as the 2023 election results, to confirm or refute the movements' long-term influence. This approach is relevant, as scholars emphasize (Amenta, Caren, Chiarello & Su, 2010) the need to address the effects of organizational

² These analytical categories are structured as follows: Resource mobilization in Thai protests (chapter 4.1), The role of political opportunity structures (chapter 4.2), and Key framing narratives and demands (chapter 4.3).

forms, framing, and political contexts that promote mobilization on achieving political influence beyond protest.

During the preparation of this thesis, I used the free version of ChatGPT as a supportive tool. I used it to check grammar, improve stylistics, and suggest alternative wording or synonyms when certain expressions were repeated. In some cases, I also used it as a translation tool when formulating ideas initially in Czech. In addition, AI provided initial inspiration for the research topic and helped me further develop the methodological approach. These suggestions were always critically assessed and examined through relevant academic literature. The text of the thesis was written by me, and I was responsible for the development of the arguments, the interpretation of the findings, and the final conclusions. At the same time, the selection of literature, work with sources, and all citations were carried out solely by me.

Literature review

The literature on the 2020–2021 Thai protests can be divided into several groups based on the focus of the research. In this section, I have identified three main types of publications. The first group focuses on the political and institutional environment. The second group looks at digital activism and social media. Finally, the third group of studies examines symbols, identities, and framing, which focus on the nature of the movements themselves.

The first group of studies focuses on Thailand's heavily controlled political environment as the primary driver of the protests. Scholars in this field investigate how the political system works and how it limits political freedom, acting as a key trigger for mass mobilization. They analyze how the structure of the constitution, the influence of elites linked to the military, and the courts losing their fairness create a political environment that pushes people to protest in the streets. A significant author on this topic is Supalak Ganjanakhundee, who in his article *Thailand in 2020: A turbulent year*, examines the political situation that followed the 2019 election. He focuses primarily on the 2017 constitution and describes how it was designed to strengthen the power of military-affiliated elites and Prime Minister Prayut Chan-o-cha. Ganjanakhundee (2021), along with other scholars (Chanlett-Avery, Dolven, & Smith, 2020; Zhang, 2022; Thomas, Beattie & Zhang, 2020) also emphasize that the dissolution of the FFP in early 2020 served as a main trigger that resurrected the student movement after four decades of relative dormancy. This political system is further explored by another key contributor to this topic, James Ockey in *Thailand in 2020: Politics, protests, and a pandemic*, where he analyzes the fragility and lack of legitimacy of the government coalition and the role of the military-appointed Senate. Ockey (2020) concludes that while the government used constitutional advantages to remain stable, its lack of legitimacy led to growing challenges in the streets and even rumors of a coup. Junsu Seo follows up on this discussion in his paper *How states violate human rights treaties: Case of the Thailand*

2020 protests, where he examines how public dissatisfaction was also linked to corruption and social inequality, such as the controversial “Red Bull heir” case³ (Seo, 2021). Collectively, these studies provide a solid foundation for understanding the political context of the protests.

Beyond the institutional focus, many studies investigate the role of technology in the protests, highlighting how digital platforms transformed traditional mobilization. Researchers in this area analyze the ways in which digital tools help communication between activists and allow for the rapid spreading of information outside of state control. They also examine the internal structure of online networks and the methods used by authorities to monitor and suppress online protests. A leading author on this topic is Aim Sinpeng, who in her article *Hashtag activism: Social media and the #Free Youth protests in Thailand*, examines how Twitter served as the primary platform for mediating protests for the first time in Thai history. She finds that the online networks of the movement were formed by weak ties and loose connections between various community clusters, warning that such networks risk being short-lived. (Sinpeng, 2021). Similarly, Tanaporn Charoenthansakul and Wannarat Natee in their article show that Twitter functioned as a key tool for immediate information sharing and a platform for expressing frustration, effectively replacing mainstream media. However, they observe that this online activity was often more about individual emotional expression than coordinated planning (Charoenthansakul & Natee, 2023). This digital conflict is further detailed by Janjira Sombatpoonsiri in *From repression to revolt: Thailand’s 2020 protests and the regional implications*, where she describes the state’s use of information operations and surveillance to create a “chilling effect” on dissent. This tactic involves using excessive legal charges and surveillance to discourage ordinary citizens from participating in activism, as the fear of potential punishment leads them to stay silent to avoid potential legal consequences (Sombatpoonsiri, 2021). Other important authors are Achmad Reynaldi, Gusni Dhiyaa, and Riswanda Imawan, who expand this to a transnational level in *Digital advocacy phenomenon in ASEAN*. By analyzing the *Milk Tea Alliance*, they prove that Thai youth were part of a sophisticated network sharing tactics with activists in Hong Kong and Taiwan (Reynaldi, Dhiyaa & Imawan, 2023). However, even though Reynaldi et al. write about the links between Thai protesters and movements abroad, there is still not enough research on this topic, specifically on how these international connections helped with the mobilization of people.

Finally, a third perspective in the literature examines the use of symbols, the movements themselves, and specific political demands that unified the protesters. These scholars focus on the interaction between popular culture and political messages, the formation of new protest groups, and the ways in which movement leaders present their objectives to challenge the established rules of Thai society. Anamwathana and

³ Vorayuth Yoovidhya, the Red Bull heir, was involved in a 2012 fatal hit-and-run case. The 2020 decision to stop his prosecution caused public outrage as it suggested that different legal standards apply based on social background and wealth (Seo, 2021).

Thanapornsangsuth are important authors in this field. In their articles *Youth participation during Thailand's 2020-2021 political turmoil* and, *Youth political participation in Thailand*, they explore the unique role of high school students. They find that these young activists, often aged 15–18, used creative pop culture references from *The Hunger Games* and *Harry Potter* as symbolic tools to exercise their rights in a space where they cannot yet vote (Anamwathana & Thanapornsangsuth, 2022, 2023). Building on this, Kanokrat Lertchoosakul, in her article *The white ribbon movement: High school students in the 2020 Thai youth protests*, interviews students about their personal views, which makes her research highly important and widely cited in this field. She argues that the movement successfully broke long-standing political taboos. She also details how organizations like *Free Youth* established the “three demands” which included an end to state intimidation, the dissolution of parliament, and the drafting of a new constitution, while others formulated a set of demands for monarchy reform (Lertchoosakul, 2021). This radical shift in the movement’s agenda is further analyzed by Duncan McCargo in *Disruptors’ dilemma? Thailand’s 2020 Gen Z protests*, who describes the movement’s tough and direct style as a challenge to the sacred image of the monarchy.

Overall, the literature on the Thai protests is very rich, offering deep research into many different topics. Scholars have documented the energy and creativity of the youth movement, providing a detailed look at how a new generation thinks about politics. However, there are still some important gaps. Although many publications about these protests have been published, there remains a notable lack of official and verified data, such as the exact number of people who participated. Furthermore, collecting primary data in the Thai context is extremely difficult because of the climate of fear created by the lèse-majesté laws. Many citizens are afraid to discuss their political views with outsiders due to potential state monitoring and legal risks. Consequently, researchers must often rely on the work of trusted local scholars, such as those cited in this thesis, who have successfully built the necessary trust to conduct interviews. A further gap in the literature is the lack of research regarding non-protesters. While some authors, such as Sombatpoonsiri (2023), elaborate on this topic, they only do so briefly. More research into the views of those who decided not to join the protests could provide a more complete picture of the role of the student movement, the government, and the monarchy. Finally, while the literature on the Thai protests is extensive, many studies remain largely descriptive and lack a clear analytical framework. This thesis addresses part of this research gap by offering a systematic, theory-based analysis of the student movement, with particular attention to framing, mobilization, and political context.

1. SOCIAL MOVEMENT THEORY

Social Movement Theory (SMT) emerged as a response to earlier explanations of collective action that portrayed protests primarily as irrational or spontaneous forms of action. Early breakdown theory⁴ understood protests as the result of mechanisms of social control losing their restraining power, with collective action seen as a reaction to dissatisfaction with the existing form of life and social order (Klandermans & Van Stekelenburg, 2009; Useem, 1998). From the late 1960s, the expanding range of social movement activity, ranging from the civil rights and student movements to feminist and environmental mobilizations, challenged these interpretations (Klandermans & Van Stekelenburg, 2009). Scholars such as Eisinger (1973), Goffman (1974), and McCarthy and Zald (1977) increasingly recognized that collective action was often purposeful, organized, and guided by clearly articulated goals and strategic calculations. This change led to the development of new theoretical approaches that sought to explain how movements mobilize resources, interact with political environments, and develop shared understandings (Klandermans & Van Stekelenburg, 2009). As a result, the study of social movements shifted toward analytical frameworks that viewed collective action as a strategic and organizational process rather than a mere psychological response to social strain (Useem, 1998).

Instead of relying on a single analytical perspective, SMT, through its different approaches, emphasizes the interaction between organizational resources, political contexts, and framing processes (Klandermans & Van Stekelenburg, 2009). These perspectives are widely applied in the analysis of both historical and recent protest movements and provide a flexible framework for understanding differences in mobilization across diverse social and political settings (Kriesi, 1991; Useem, 1998; Jamil, 2018; Putri, 2024).

1.1. Core approaches

SMT is commonly structured around three core analytical approaches, namely resource mobilization, political opportunity structure, and framing. Taken together, these perspectives have come to represent a dominant framework within much of the North American and European literature on social movements over the past decades (Nulman & Schlembach, 2018; Klandermans & Van Stekelenburg, 2009).

While each of these approaches effectively explains a specific aspect of collective action, none of them is sufficient on its own to fully account for the complexity of social movements (Koopmans, 1999; Ruedin, 2011; Chakraborty, 2024). Resource mobilization

⁴ Breakdown theory dominated early sociological explanations of collective action. Its theoretical dominance declined during the 1970s, as scholars increasingly argued that it could not adequately account for societal events as they were unfolding. These limitations contributed to the emergence of alternative approaches, most notably resource mobilization theory (Useem, 1998).

emphasizes the organizational, material, and human resources that enable sustained mobilization (Goodwin & Jasper, 2015). The political opportunity structure approach focuses on how characteristics of the political environment, such as institutional openness, elite alignments, or state repression, create openings or constraints for collective action (Ruedin, 2011; De Moor, 2016). Lastly, framing draws attention to how movements create shared understandings, identify problems, and motivate participation (Snow & Benford, 1988). Treating these perspectives as analytically complementary allows for a more complete understanding of social movements than relying on any single approach alone. By combining insights from resource mobilization, political opportunity structure, and framing, it becomes possible to account for the organizational, political, and interpretive dynamics that shape the emergence and development of recent protest movements (Morris, 2000). The following subsections therefore outline each approach in greater detail and clarify their relevance for the subsequent analysis.

1.1.1. Resource mobilization

The *resource mobilization* (RM) approach focuses on the resources and organizational strength which enables social movements to emerge, persist, and succeed. Rather than viewing collective action as a natural reaction to shared grievances, this perspective emphasizes the importance of societal support, constraints, external linkages, and strategic interactions between movements and authorities (Goodwin & Jasper, 2015). A central problem addressed by RM theory, developed most notably by McCarthy and Zald (1977), is Olson's (1965) challenge of collective action (McCarthy & Zald, 1977; Crossman, 2020). Because social movements aim to produce collective goods, individuals may be reluctant to participate if they can benefit without bearing the costs. From this perspective, participation is not automatic but depends on the availability of incentives, organizational support, and resources that reduce individual costs and encourage involvement (Goodwin & Jasper, 2015).

Several key assumptions define the RM perspective. First, the aggregation of resources, such as money, labor, and skills, is essential for long-term collective action (Rohman, 2023). Second, mobilizing these resources requires at least a minimal level of organization, which leads this perspective to focus more directly on social movement organizations than do more traditional approaches (McCarthy & Zald, 1977). Third, the success or failure of movements often depends on support from external actors, including allied organizations, or donor networks (Rohman, 2023). Finally, the perspective highlights the role of costs and rewards in shaping participation, acknowledging that these are strongly affected by the structure of society and the activities of authorities (McCarthy & Zald, 1977; Goodwin & Jasper, 2015).

RM theory also draws attention to the strategic tasks faced by social movement organizations. These include mobilizing supporters, shaping public opinion, negotiating with elites, and selecting tactics that balance conflicting goals. Movements often face

dilemmas in choosing strategies, as actions that mobilize supporters may provoke repression or undermine alliances (Goodwin & Jasper, 2015). Such choices are further shaped by competition and cooperation among groups operating in the same political environment. From this perspective, the long-term survival of social movements depends largely on their ability to secure and maintain key resources. Human participation, financial support, social and organizational resources, as well as cultural and moral resources, are crucial for maintaining activism over time (Edwards & Gillham, 2013). Movements may decline when activists withdraw, lose financial support from donor agencies, or repression interferes with organizational activities. Limited access to funding or personnel can significantly constrain movement's capacity to continue its activities, regardless of the strength of its grievances (Rohman, 2023).

While RM theory provides a powerful framework for understanding how movements organize and remain active, it has been criticized (Piven & Cloward, 1991; Buechler, 1993; Chakraborty, 2024) for underestimating the role of political context and for neglecting social-psychological processes. These limitations have led scholars to complement it with the political opportunity structure and framing perspectives, which address how political conditions and shared interpretations shape processes of mobilization (Ruedin, 2011; Chakraborty, 2024).

1.1.2. Political opportunity structure

The *political opportunity structure* (POS) approach emerged from the recognition that shared grievances alone are insufficient to explain the emergence and success of social movements. Instead, it shifts attention toward the relationship between social movements and their broader political environment (Ruedin, 2011), emphasizing how institutions, power relations, and political contexts shape opportunities for collective action (De Moor, 2016).

POS was first introduced by Eisinger (1973), who examined how differences in institutional openness and governmental responsiveness influenced protest activity in American cities. His analysis showed that highly closed political systems tended to suppress protest, while highly responsive governments often resolved grievances before they developed into collective action. Protest was most likely to take place in contexts of partial openness, where some political access existed but reform efforts remained limited, creating expectations of change that were not yet fulfilled (Berclaz & Giugni, 2005; Nulman & Schlembach, 2018). The concept was later further developed by Charles Tilly. In *From Mobilization to Revolution* (1978), Tilly expanded the POS framework through national comparisons and an analysis of changes over time, focusing on how formal institutional rules shape opportunities for social movements (Berclaz & Giugni, 2005; Gomes, 2023). At its core, the POS approach views social movements as operating within broader political and social contexts that both limit and enable their actions (Nulman & Schlembach, 2018). Political institutions, elite alignments, and interaction between the

state and social movements shape opportunities for mobilization as well as the chances of success (NeJaime, 2013). Similar to resource mobilization theory, POS approaches generally assume that social movements and political actors act rationally, adjusting their strategies in response to perceived opportunities and constraints (Ruedin, 2011).

Scholars (Kriesi, 2004; Ruedin, 2011; De Moor, 2016) often distinguish between stable and dynamic political opportunities. Stable opportunities refer to the broader structural setting of a political system, including aspects such as state capacity, the openness or closure of political system, electoral rules, the number of political parties as a sign of openness, and the availability of access points for interest groups and social movements. These opportunities can change, but usually only slowly over time. Dynamic opportunities, by contrast, relate to more short-term political developments, such as changes in government composition, shifts in political alliances, divisions among elites, periods of political instability, or the presence of influential allies within the political system (Ruedin, 2011; De Moor, 2016). Together, stable and dynamic opportunities determine how easily challengers can gain access to the political decision-making process and mobilize collectively (De Moor, 2016). Importantly, political opportunities are not equally available to all actors. A central question within the POS framework is therefore “political opportunities for whom,” as the same political structures can make mobilization easier for some groups while limiting it for others (Ruedin, 2011). For example, while institutional openness may formally exist, marginalized groups such as migrants often lack citizenship rights or political access necessary to fully exploit these opportunities. The same political context can lead to different mobilization outcomes across different social actors (Berclaz & Giugni, 2005). Political opportunities may also arise unexpectedly or be created through the strategic actions of activists. Social movements can benefit from regime changes, shifts in governance, or newly formed alliances with political elites, lobbyists, or other influential actors (De Moor, 2016; Rohman, 2023). These opportunities can make it easier to gain access to resources, external support, and influence over policymaking, thereby contributing to the persistence and renewed mobilization of movements over time (Rohman, 2023).

Similarly to resource mobilization theory, the political opportunity structure approach captures only part of social movement dynamics. While it helps explain patterns of mobilization and differences in movement success, it cannot on its own fully explain the broader development of social movements (Koopmans, 1999; Ruedin, 2011). Its analytical value therefore lies in its use alongside complementary perspectives, particularly resource mobilization and framing, which address organizational resources and shared interpretations. (Chakraborty, 2024; Putri, 2024)

1.1.3. Framing

Within *Social Movement Theory* (SMT), the concept of framing highlights the role of movements in shaping how social problems are defined, understood, and

communicated (Almeida, 2019). Building on the work of Erving Goffman, who introduced frames as principles of organization through which individuals interpret situations and experiences (Goffman, 1974), the framing perspective was further developed by Snow, Benford, Worden and Rochford (1986) in the late 1980s (Chakraborty, 2024). Their work introduced framing as a key analytical tool for understanding how movement actors create shared interpretive frameworks through which problems are defined, solutions proposed, and participation encouraged (Snow & Benford, 1988). Since the 1990s, framing has become one of the most widely used perspectives in social movement research (Nulman & Schlembach, 2018). In SMT, a frame refers to a way of understanding reality that highlights certain events and facts while rendering others invisible (Goodwin & Jasper, 2015). Frames are cognitive shortcuts that people use to help make sense of complex information. They allow individuals to interpret the world around them and to communicate these interpretations to others. Framing, in turn, refers to the ongoing process through which movement actors create, modify, and share these frames (Kaufman, Elliott & Shmueli, 2003). As Goodwin and Jasper (2015) note, framing is not merely a way of presenting ideas to external audiences, but a strategic process through which a particular group seeks to form a unified movement.

Snow and Benford (1988) identify three main framing tasks that are essential to the functioning of social movements, namely *diagnostic*, *prognostic*, and *motivational framing*. Diagnostic framing involves identifying a problem and attributing responsibility or blame. Prognostic framing focuses on proposing solutions and strategies to address the identified problem. Finally, motivational framing provides reasons for action by encouraging individuals to participate through various forms of inducements. Together, these framing tasks affect the mobilizing potential of movement framing efforts. In addition to these core tasks, framing also involves processes of frame alignment, through which movements seek to connect their ways of understanding social problems with the beliefs and experiences of broader audiences (Almeida, 2019). These processes include frame bridging, which links two or more similar grievances across different groups; frame amplification, which strengthens existing values or beliefs; frame extension, which brings additional issues into the movement's message; and frame transformation, which seeks to change how issues are understood (Snow, Rochford, Worden & Benford, 1986). Successful frame alignment increases the likelihood that individuals will recognize their own experiences within a movement's message and choose to become involved in the movement (Almeida, 2019).

Framing is particularly important in contexts characterized by repression and limited political opportunities. When institutional channels for participation are restricted, framing helps sustain movements by providing shared meanings, reinforcing commitment, and maintaining ideological unity over time (Qiaoan & Saxonberg, 2022; Rohman, 2023). As Rohman (2023) argues, in hostile political environments, framing and ideology can become key resources that enable movements to persist despite legal

pressure, surveillance, and repression. In such settings, framing not only helps mobilization but also supports movement continuity during periods of decline. Importantly, rather than replacing other approaches on social movements, the framing perspective highlights processes that they often overlook, particularly the production of mobilizing and countermobilizing meanings and ideas (Snow, Vliegenthart & Ketelaars, 2019).

2. POLITICAL AND SOCIAL CONTEXT OF THAILAND

This chapter outlines the political and social context within which the 2020 protests in Thailand emerged. It examines the institutional structure of the political system, key political developments following the 2014 military coup, and the gradual restriction of civil liberties and political discourse. Together, these factors help explain the limits on traditional political participation and the conditions that shaped protest mobilization, particularly among students.

2.1 Political system overview

To understand the 2020–2021 student movements, it is first necessary to elaborate on the political system of Thailand, which is characterized by a persistent tension between written law and informal power (Connors and Pathmanand, 2021). A powerful frame for interpreting this environment is the concept of the *supra-constitution*. As described by Connors and Pathmanand (2021), this unwritten order exists above Thailand’s numerous formal constitutions and consists of evolving norms regarding military and monarchical authority, which limit democratic participation. The supra-constitution reflects a system in which informal power, exercised primarily by kings and generals, repeatedly overrules the written constitutional order, resulting in a cycle where formal documents are drafted with the expectation that they may eventually be revoked. Consequently, Thailand can be described as a *tutelary democracy*, in which politicians can participate in elections, but tutelary powers, specifically the monarchy and the army, retain the authority to veto decisions and maintain ultimate control over the political system (Mérieau, 2019). Since the 2014 military coup, from which the current political establishment emerged, this system has been strengthened through a series of legislative and institutional changes designed to protect the dominance of the military and royalist elites (Takahashi, 2022).

The 2017 constitution, Thailand’s twentieth since 1932,⁵ plays a key role in this process. Rather than promoting political reconciliation, the constitution significantly strengthens the power of non-elected institutions, including the military, the bureaucracy, and the judiciary (Lertchoosakul, 2020). Within this framework, traditional military coups are no longer necessary, as the military can now achieve its goals through constitutional means. At the core of this system is the Constitutional Court, which, supported by independent organs such as the Election Commission, has the power to dismiss elected leaders and dissolve political parties (Mérieau, 2019). These powers are based on electoral and party laws adopted after 2017, which give wide and often unclear authority to unelected institutions.⁶ To ensure continued military alignment, the 2017

⁵ The year 1932 represents a key turning point in Thai history, as the Siamese Revolution initiated the formal transition from an absolute monarchy to a constitutional one (Chaiching, 2018).

⁶ The 2017 Political Party Act specifies the grounds on which political parties may be dissolved by the Constitutional Court, while the 2018 Act on the Election of Members of the House of Representatives further expands this list. Many of these rules are broad and unclear, including offences such as a “failure to act according to the Democracy with the King as Head of State” (Mérieau, 2019).

constitution dictates that Constitutional Court judges must be approved by the Senate, a 250-member body entirely appointed by the military (Ganjanakhundee, 2021; Mérieau, 2019).

In addition to the judiciary, the Thai state has experienced significant militarization. Since 2018, the *National Council for Peace and Order* (NCPO) and King Vajiralongkorn (Rama X) have appointed military officers to hundreds of key positions throughout the state institutions (Mérieau, 2019). At the same time, the King, who ascended the throne in 2016, appears to have embraced a vision aimed at bringing back aspects of an absolute monarchy, undermining the legacy of the 1932 revolution (Takahashi, 2022). This shift is particularly evident in the King's efforts to expand royal authority over institutions previously overseen by the government, such as the *Buddhist Supreme Patriarch* and the *Crown Property Bureau*. In 2018, the *Crown Property Act* was amended to allow the King to personally decide disputes regarding royal assets, further consolidating royal control (Mérieau, 2019). The monarch's political involvement was also shown by his public praise for royalist counterprotesters, indicating state support for those opposing the student movement (Chanlett-Avery, Dolven, & Smith, 2020).

The March 2019 election, while formally dissolving the junta, was conducted under conditions that ensured the military's retention of power. The 2017 constitution allowed Prayut Chan-o-cha to become Prime Minister despite not being a member of any political party (Ganjanakhundee, 2021). Furthermore, a novel single ballot electoral system was introduced to weaken the legislature. By removing a minimum threshold for seats and favoring medium-sized parties, the system was designed to weaken major opposition parties such as *Pheu Thai* and ensure a fragile multi-party coalition that remains easier for the military to manipulate (Lertchoosakul, 2020). This political setting shaped the opportunity structure within which student movements emerged and operated.

2.2 Political developments before 2020

The political developments leading up to the 2020–2021 protests were shaped by long-term instability, repeated military interventions, and the controversial 2019 general election, which strengthened the military's influence and deepened growing generational frustration with Thailand's semi-authoritarian political order (Ockey, 2021; Seo, 2021). While coups have been common in Thai politics throughout the 20th century, political conflict in the 21st century became increasingly structured around a struggle between two major sides (Chanlett-Avery, Dolven, & Smith, 2020). The "Red Shirts" were largely made up of rural and lower-income groups supporting former Prime Minister Thaksin Shinawatra, while the "Yellow Shirts" represented urban elites and supporters of military intervention (Anamwathana & Thanapornsanguth, 2023; Chanlett-Avery, Dolven, & Smith, 2020). This period of political division intensified after 2005 and led to military coups in 2006 and 2014, both of which were justified by the armed forces as necessary

interventions to protect the monarchy and restore political order (Ockey, 2021; Connors & Pathmanand, 2021).

For the generation that led the 2020 protests, military dominance has played a central role in shaping their political views. Student activists have spent roughly a third of their lives under the authoritarian rule that followed the 2014 coup (Ockey, 2021). Under the leadership of General Prayut Chan-o-cha, the military government faced growing criticism for its economic management, restrictions on freedom of expression, and overall governance performance (Sombatpoonsiri, 2021; Seo, 2021). Research involving students by Anamwathana and Thanapornsangsuth (2023) indicates widespread perceptions of declining living standards, rising costs of living, and prolonged economic insecurity, with many respondents reporting that their families were worse off than before the coup. This period was further shaped by institutional changes introduced after the 2014 coup, particularly the 2017 Constitution, which strengthened the military's influence over electoral politics through an appointed Senate and restrictive rules for political parties⁷ (Mérieau, 2019). In addition, electoral rules made it difficult for any single party to secure a clear parliamentary majority, reinforcing the continued influence of the military in the creation of governments (Tonsakulrungruang, 2020a; Rattanakit, 2024). These institutional constraints limited the ability of elected actors to effectively challenge entrenched military and monarchical influence and continued to shape political outcomes, including those of the 2023 general election (Mérieau, 2019; Schuldt, 2026).

Despite these limitations, the 2019 general election represented a partial opening within this constrained political environment,⁸ though its fairness was undermined by several issues highlighted by the *Asian Network for Free Elections* (ANFREL, 2019). These issues included the sudden halt of the live vote count due to data discrepancies and an unusually high number of invalid ballots, which exceeded two million (5.57%). Furthermore, while previous elections saw unofficial results within hours, the 2019 results were not released until four days later, indicating a lack of transparency that fueled public suspicion of electoral fraud. This delay was followed by the post-election publication of the used seat-allocation formula that was significantly different from the method previously agreed upon by all political parties (ANFREL, 2019). Within this constrained space, a key development was the rapid rise of the *Future Forward Party* (FFP), led by Thanathorn Juangroongruangkit. Unlike traditional opposition parties rooted in the Red–Yellow conflict, the FFP articulated a new political agenda that explicitly appealed to younger voters (Seo, 2021). The party's program, which included limiting the military's role in politics and promoting social equity, resonated with millions

⁷ These include restrictions regarding membership, finance, and candidacy (Tonsakulrungruang, 2020a). A notable example is *Order No. 53/2560*, which gave party members only 30 days to confirm their affiliation. Many members were unable to comply with this brief timeframe, leading to a significant drop in membership for the main political parties (Pookaman, 2018).

⁸ After five years of direct military rule and repeated postponements, the 2019 general election represented the first formal opportunity for Thai citizens to participate in the political process and express opposition to the military's dominance (ANFREL, 2019).

of first-time voters (Chanlett-Avery, Dolven, & Smith, 2020). Although founded only in 2018, the party emerged as the third-largest force in the House of Representatives, signaling a significant generational shift in political preferences (Seo, 2021). Importantly, the FFP did not simply seek electoral success within the current rules but openly questioned the legitimacy of unelected institutions, making it a direct challenge to the post-2014 political system (Gunia, 2020).

This challenge was quickly met with legal action. In February 2020, the Constitutional Court ordered the dissolution of the FFP (Lertchoosakul, 2021). While the dissolution was formally justified by violations of party funding rules, McCargo (2023) notes that FFP was subjected to an unusually high number of lawsuits during its short existence. These cases, many of which were described as opportunistic or minor, consumed significant time and resources and showed that the party was seen as an existential threat to the conservative, military-backed political order. The dissolution is widely regarded as the immediate political trigger of the 2020 protest wave (Seo, 2021; Ganjanakhundee, 2021; Zhang, 2022; Thomas, Beattie & Zhang, 2020). For many students, the decision symbolized the suppression of peaceful and formal ways for democratic change, confirming the belief that electoral politics alone could not produce meaningful reform (Carter, 2020; International Affairs, 2024).

While the dissolution of the FFP represented a critical political trigger, broader social and economic dissatisfaction further intensified public frustration. Public trust in the state was weakened by well-known cases where the elites seemed to be above the law, most notably the Red Bull case (Seo, 2021). These growing feelings of injustice were deepened by the abduction of activist Wanchalearm Satsaksit,⁹ who came to represent the dangers of speaking out against the government. (Sombatpoonsiri, 2021). Together, these developments marked a turning point, transforming long-standing dissatisfaction into open political confrontation. On June 24, 2020, the anniversary of the 1932 revolution, public demonstrations re-emerged with demands for the prime minister's resignation, the dissolution of parliament, and democratic reform, drawing on the legacy of earlier student movements in 1973 and 1976 (Ockey, 2021; Ganjanakhundee, 2021).

2.3 State of civil liberties and political discourse

The political environment preceding the 2020 protests was marked by a gradual weakening of civil liberties and limits on acceptable political discourse. Following the 2014 coup, restrictions on freedom of expression, assembly, and association became a defining feature of Thailand's political landscape (The Right of Peaceful Assembly, 2021). While these freedoms are formally guaranteed, protest gatherings were frequently

⁹ Wanchalearm Satsaksit, a prominent Thai pro-democracy activist living in exile since the 2014 coup, was kidnapped in Phnom Penh on June 4, 2020, and remains missing. He is the ninth exiled critic of Thailand's political system to become a victim of forced disappearance in recent years (Wright & Praithongyaem, 2020).

dispersed by the police, and authorities relied on emergency powers and digital regulations to limit coordination among activists, further reducing the space for traditional political participation and dissent (U.S. Department of State, 2021).

A central instrument in constraining political expression has been Article 112 of the Thai Criminal Code, commonly referred to as the *lèse-majesté* law. Although this law had been used selectively in earlier periods, its reinstatement in late 2020 showed a clear response to the 2020 protest movements by suppressing criticism of the monarchy (FIDH, 2021). Under Article 112, individuals accused of insulting or defaming the royal family face severe prison sentences, which has a strong discouraging effect on open debate (Manushya Foundation, 2020a). According to *Thai Lawyers for Human Rights*, thousands of individuals have faced legal action since 2020, with a significant number charged under Article 112, contributing to an atmosphere of fear that limited open discussion (Yeluri, 2023).

Legal repression also extended beyond *lèse-majesté* cases. Authorities have relied on a combination of emergency decrees, laws regulating public order, and the Computer Crime Act to restrict freedom of expression and criminalize dissent, particularly in digital spaces (FIDH, 2021). During the COVID-19 pandemic, the government used the health crisis as a justification for imposing emergency powers, which were renewed nine times by February 2021, enabling authorities to ban public gatherings and take legal action against critics of its crisis management, further limiting opportunities for political participation (Sombatpoonsiri, 2021). These measures conflicted with Thailand's international human rights obligations, including protections of freedom of expression under the *International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights* (ICCPR) (Seo, 2021).

These restrictions also extended to traditional and online media. During the state of emergency in October 2020, the government used emergency powers and digital security laws to censor critical news media. Most notably, the outspoken *Voice TV* channel was temporarily shut down following its coverage of pro-democracy protests, with authorities claiming that it violated rules of the *Emergency Decree and the Computer-Related Crime Act* (Human Rights Watch, 2020a). Similar shutdown orders were sought against other independent media platforms, including *Prachatai*, *The Reporters*, and *The Standard*. Such actions resulted in more cautious reporting, which left the public with fewer sources of critical information and increased the importance of social media as an alternative space for political communication (Amnesty International, 2020).

At the same time, political discourse has increasingly shifted to the online space, which became both an important place for opposition mobilization and a key area of state control (Thomas, Beattie & Zhang, 2020). While anti-establishment actors used social media platforms to challenge the legitimacy of ruling elites and their ideology, the authorities and pro-regime royalist groups responded with coordinated digital repression (Sombatpoonsiri, 2022). This included online surveillance and disinformation campaigns

aimed at discrediting protest movements and reinforcing official ideologies surrounding the monarchy (Ganjanakhundee, 2021; Sombatpoonsiri, 2021). Royalist digital activism played a particularly important role in this process. Pro-regime royalist accounts promoted hashtags emphasizing loyalty to the monarchy and framed those expressing criticism as immoral (Sombatpoonsiri, 2023). Although such campaigns often attracted limited engagement, their impact was strengthened through close cooperation with state institutions. Royalist groups monitored online content, reported perceived violations to the authorities, and contributed to the practice of lawfare, in which unclear and restrictive laws were used to intimidate and punish critics (Sombatpoonsiri, 2022).

As a result, the limits of acceptable political discourse became increasingly restricted (Seo, 2021). Criticism of the monarchy, the military, or the overall political system carried significant legal and personal risks, while formal ways of political participation were heavily restricted (Sombatpoonsiri, 2022). Under these conditions, political claims were often expressed in symbolic and indirect forms, frequently through online platforms, which is important for understanding the framing strategies used by the student movements (Handley, 2020).

3. 2020-2021 PRO-DEMOCRACY STUDENT MOVEMENTS

Building on the broader political and institutional context outlined in the previous chapters, this section focuses on the 2020–2021 pro-democracy student protests in Thailand. It introduces the key developments that preceded and accompanied the protests and outlines the main actors, central demands, and governmental responses that shaped their trajectory.

Tensions between young voters' expectations of political change and the constraints of the existing political system became particularly visible in the aftermath of the 2019 general election, most notably in connection with the rise and subsequent dissolution of the *Future Forward Party* (FFP). The party attracted substantial support among young voters by articulating demands for political reform and greater social equality (Chanlett-Avery, Dolven, & Smith, 2020). Its dissolution by the Constitutional Court eliminated a key channel of formal political opposition and reinforced feelings of political exclusion among students and first-time voters (Sombatpoonsiri, 2025). This event is therefore frequently identified as a key trigger of the student-led protests that followed (Chanlett-Avery, Dolven, & Smith, 2020; Zhang, 2022; Thomas, Beattie & Zhang, 2020). At the same time, public dissatisfaction extended beyond party politics. Years of military rule following the 2014 coup had generated accumulated grievances related not only to electoral fairness, but also to economic performance, educational policy, gender rights, and restrictions on freedom of expression (Ganjanakhundee, 2021; Seo, 2021). Questions concerning the role of the monarchy and the social and political direction of the country, long considered sensitive or taboo, increasingly entered public debate. (Ganjanakhundee, 2021; Lertchoosakul, 2021).

Universities played a central role as areas of mobilization and political expression. Following the dissolution of the FFP, student-led demonstrations rapidly spread across university campuses, with institutions such as *Thammasat University*, historically associated with student activism and opposition to the authoritarian rule, emerging as key sites of protest (Seo, 2021; Ganjanakhundee, 2021). While the initial mobilization was driven primarily by university students, it soon expanded to include high school and college students and gradually evolved into a more socially diverse youth-led movement (Anamwathana & Thanapornsanguth, 2023). Although students remained at its core, the protests increasingly attracted junior office workers, activists, Buddhist monks, celebrities, LGBTQ advocates, and former Red Shirt supporters, reflecting both generational frustration and the absence of effective channels for political participation during the previous years (Ganjanakhundee, 2021; Anamwathana & Thanapornsanguth, 2023).

At the organizational level, the movement was characterized by a highly decentralized and networked structure. Rather than operating through formal organizations, youth activists mobilized through loosely coordinated groups

(Sombatpoonsiri, 2023). Key actors included the *Free Youth Movement* (FYM), the *United Front of Thammasat and Demonstration*, *Free People*, and *Khanaratsadon 2563* (People's Party 2020) (Ganjanakhundee, 2021; Sinpeng, 2021; Ladia, 2022). Although several individuals, such as Parit Chiwarak, Panusaya Sithijirawattanakul, Jatupat Boonpattaraksa, and Arnon Nampa, gained public visibility, they did not hold formal leadership positions. Instead, the movement was unified by a shared opposition to the existing political order, despite variation in priorities and issue focus across groups (Ganjanakhundee, 2021; Anamwathana & Thanapornsangsuth, 2023).

The *Free Youth Movement* (FYM) played a particularly important role during the early stages of mobilization. Originally launched in November 2019 as a Facebook discussion space, FYM aimed to provide young people with a platform to exchange views on Thailand's future (Manushya Foundation, 2020b). In the aftermath of the dissolution of the *Future Forward Party*, FYM quickly transformed into a central actor and inspired other groups to mobilize, including *Free People*, *Free Chiang Rai*, *Free Monks*, *Free Taxi Drivers*, and *Parents of Free Youth* (Sinpeng, 2021). Together with other allied actors, the FYM was involved in organizing more than a dozen large-scale protests between July and December 2020, which brought together hundreds of thousands of participants across Thailand (McCargo, 2021; Sinpeng, 2021). This rapid growth was closely linked to the movement's effective use of digital media. Supported by dedicated social media coordinators, FYM's online presence allowed protest information to spread quickly and helped connect participants across different parts of the country (Alexander, 2021; Sinpeng, 2021). Hashtag campaigns, most notably #FreeYouth (#เยาวชนปลดแอก), served as important tools for visibility, mobilization, and moral support among participants (Charoenthansakul & Natee, 2023). A particularly visible group of this youth activism was formed by high school students associated with the *Nakrianleo* (Bad Student) movement, who organized independent protests addressing school-related issues, including strict dress codes, the social studies curriculum, and disciplinary measures within schools (Feigenblatt, Pardo & Cooper, 2021). Their initiatives often took symbolic and performative forms, such as music performances, satirical plays, and interactive public displays, highlighting the creative dimension of the protests (Anamwathana & Thanapornsangsuth, 2023).

Building upon the organizational development and symbolic forms of protest, the movement articulated a set of increasingly expansive political demands. Early flash-mob demonstrations called for Prime Minister Prayut Chan-o-cha to resign, for the dissolution of parliament, and for the drafting of a new constitution (Ockey, 2021; Lertchoosakul, 2021). These three core demands quickly became a common set of demands across protest sites (Ockey, 2021). As mobilization intensified, calls for broader institutional reform expanded beyond the ruling political authorities and increasingly focused on the role of the monarchy (Sombatpoonsiri, 2021). On August 10, 2020, a ten-point manifesto outlining proposals for monarchy reform was publicly announced by activists associated with the *United Front of Thammasat and Demonstration* (Lertchoosakul, 2021). Its

demands included the removal of royal legal immunity, the repeal of the *lèse-majesté* law and amnesty for those prosecuted under it, and greater transparency regarding royal finances and assets. Protesters also called for reductions in public funding allocated to the monarchy, the abolition of royal offices within the government, and public scrutiny of donations made to royal charities. Further demands sought to restrict the monarchy's direct political influence, including prohibiting the monarch from expressing political opinions, or endorsing future coups. The manifesto also addressed social aspects, calling for an end to state-led propaganda and education that excessively glorify the monarchy, as well as investigations into the disappearance and deaths of regime critics. (Chanlett-Avery, Dolven, & Smith, 2020). Although many student leaders emphasized that their intention was not to abolish the monarchy but to redefine its role within the constitutional system, the articulation of such demands in itself set the movement apart from earlier student mobilizations (Ockey, 2021; Seo, 2021). The movement also linked its demands to generational interests. Student activists emphasized their right to political expression and argued that current political decisions would shape their future (Anamwathana & Thanapornsanguth, 2023). References to the 1932 revolution further connected the protests to earlier struggles for constitutional order (Ockey, 2021).

The governmental response evolved over time. Initially, authorities relied on warnings, public criticism, and pressure on educational institutions to contain the protests (Ockey, 2021). However, as demonstrations continued, repression intensified. Protest leaders were arrested and charged with sedition and, increasingly, with violations of the *lèse-majesté* law (Alexander, 2021; Anamwathana & Thanapornsanguth, 2023). By early 2021, dozens of activists had faced charges under Article 112. Law enforcement authorities also employed emergency decrees, water cannons, tear gas, and rubber bullets to disperse gatherings, marking a significant escalation compared to the initial phase (Seo, 2021; Charoenthansakul & Natee, 2023). In addition to physical repression, digital spaces became sites of contention. Authorities warned social media users against sharing protest-related content and sought to counter online mobilization through information control strategies (Sombatpoonsiri, 2021; Seo, 2021). The combination of legal prosecution, public order measures, and digital monitoring reflected the government's comprehensive strategy aimed at containing the movement.

4. ANALYTICAL PART

This chapter uses key concepts of *Social Movement Theory* to map and analyze the emergence and development of the Thai student movement during the 2020–2021 pro-democracy protests. In particular, the analysis focuses on three perspectives commonly used in the study of social movements, namely political opportunity structures, resource mobilization, and framing (Nulman & Schlembach, 2018). This framework is widely applied in the analysis of both historical and contemporary protest movements and thus provides a useful tool for examining mobilization in different political and social contexts (Kriesi, 1991; Useem, 1998; Jamil, 2018; Putri, 2024). Using these perspectives helps address the research questions concerning how student movements mobilized and formulated their demands, how the government responded to these protests, and how the movement was reflected in political discourse.

4.1. Resource mobilization in Thai protests

From the *resource mobilization* (RM) perspective, social movements succeed not only because of grievances but because they are able to acquire, organize, and strategically deploy resources (McCarthy & Zald, 1977). In the case of the 2020–2021 Thai student protests, digital platforms functioned as one of the most important core resources. Social media platforms such as Twitter, Facebook, Telegram, Instagram, TikTok, and LINE were not merely communication tools but operated as organizational, mobilizing, cultural, and protective¹⁰ resources that enabled the movement to function under conditions of political repression (Edwards & Gillham, 2013; Ganjanakhundee, 2021; Srisai, 2025). Twitter played a particularly important role in shaping protest narratives and supporting pro-democracy ideas. Within protest-related hashtags such as #FreeYouth, digital communication focused heavily on grievances toward the government and demands for democratic reform (Sinpeng, 2021; Charoenthansakul & Natee, 2023). Rather than serving as the main tool for organizing protest events, Twitter functioned as a space for the construction and reinforcement of collective action frames (Sinpeng, 2021). In this sense, the platform operated as a discursive resource that strengthened collective identity and sustained mobilization over time.

A similar pattern can be observed across other major protest-related hashtags,¹¹ where online content focused on information sharing, expressions of frustration, moral support, and calls for action (Charoenthansakul & Natee, 2023). The emotionally expressive

¹⁰ Protective resources refer to the way digital visibility, particularly through livestreaming, can increase public scrutiny of state actions and raise the reputational costs of repression. In the Thai case, livestreamed arrests and online circulation of protest footage exposed police responses to wider audiences (Reed, 2020b; Srisai, 2025).

¹¹ Such as #28FebMob, #18JulMob, and #7AugMob, which were among the most frequently used protest-related hashtags in 2021 (Charoenthansakul & Natee, 2023). Other prominent hashtags included #FreeYouth (Sinpeng, 2021), #WhatsHappeningInThailand, and #WhyDoWeNeedAKing, which openly questioned the role of the monarchy (Reed, 2020a).

character of many posts should not be understood as spontaneous anger alone. From a *resource mobilization* (RM) perspective, such expressions contributed to the accumulation of non-material resources, particularly solidarity (McCarthy & Zald, 1977) and collective identity, which are essential for sustaining political activism over time. As a digital resource, Twitter extended the movement's ability to articulate and spread reform-oriented views. The platform played an important role in normalizing public discussion of previously sensitive political issues (Sombatpoonsiri, 2023). Within the #FreeYouth, activists openly debated government accountability and constitutional reform, contributing to a broader shift in what could be publicly articulated in Thai politics (Sinpeng, 2021). At the same time, hashtags such as #WhyDoWeNeedAKing publicly questioned the role of the monarchy and further expanded these boundaries (Reed, 2020a).

While Twitter functioned primarily as a discursive space, Facebook played a more direct organizational role. In practice, this meant enabling coordination among activists, organizing protest activities, and broadcasting protest messages. (Jha, 2020; Ganjanakhundee, 2021; Ockey, 2021). In this respect, Facebook can be understood as a key organizational tool that reduced the time and resources required to coordinate protest events and lowered barriers to participation. This organizational logic was further reflected in the circulation of the hashtag #everybodyisaleader, which promoted decentralized leadership and distributed responsibility across participants, thereby reducing the movement's vulnerability to targeted repression (Jha, 2020). Similarly, livestreaming represented a particularly significant strategic adaptation on Facebook. Activists transformed arrests into public online events by broadcasting them in real time (Reed, 2020b). Livestreams therefore functioned not only as communication, but as a mechanism that partially mitigated the risks associated with protest participation. The case of the *Royalist Marketplace* Facebook group further illustrates the importance of online platforms as organizational resources. When Thai authorities requested Facebook to restrict access to the group within Thailand, the platform complied. However, a new group was quickly created and gained hundreds of thousands of members in a short time (Suliman, 2020). This case therefore points to both the vulnerability and resilience of digital activism, as state efforts to limit online spaces were followed by their immediate reconstruction.

Alongside Facebook, Telegram became especially important resource once the government implemented restrictions on public gatherings. Protesters used the platform to coordinate rallies, share updates about police movements, and discuss tactical decisions (Jha, 2020). Furthermore, the platform played a key role in enabling activists to evade government surveillance (Khaosod English, 2020). A Telegram group initiated by *Free Youth* quickly reached its maximum capacity of 200,000 subscribers, indicating the scale of digital mobilization (Jha, 2020). As with Facebook, authorities responded by ordering internet providers to block the application, further demonstrating their concern over digital coordination. (Khaosod English, 2020).

Online platforms also expanded the movement's network resources beyond national borders. The *Milk Tea Alliance* connected activists in Thailand, Hong Kong, Taiwan, Myanmar, and other locations, encouraging transnational solidarity and a sense of shared struggle (Kreutz & Makrogianni, 2024). As Chachavalpongpun (2020) notes, Thai protesters drew inspiration from Hong Kong activist Joshua Wong and exchanged protest strategies and organizational knowledge with their regional counterparts, which reflects an effective mobilization of organizational and human resources across national borders. These cross-border digital connections provided greater symbolic legitimacy, moral support, and international visibility (Kreutz & Makrogianni, 2024). The hashtag #WhatsHappeningInThailand similarly functioned as a global awareness tool, allowing activists to evade domestic media censorship and share information internationally (Reed, 2020a; Srisai, 2025). Through the lens of RM, these transnational digital ties are seen as an expansion of the movement's network and cultural resources (Edwards & Gillham, 2013), which strengthened its capacity to sustain mobilization despite domestic constraints.

In addition to expanding transnational networks, online platforms also enabled the protests to maintain momentum beyond physical gatherings. While physical protests provided visible forms of dissent, social media allowed the movement to continue spreading information, organizing events, debating strategy, and maintaining engagement (Srisai, 2025) even during lockdown conditions. During the COVID-19 pandemic, many students were "living entirely online," (Reed, 2020a) which further intensified digital political engagement. In this sense, online platforms made participation more flexible and accessible by allowing individuals to engage with the movement at different levels of commitment, thereby broadening the movement's support base. From a resource mobilization perspective, digital platforms operated not only as organizational tools but also as contested political arenas. State attempts to restrict access reflected their mobilizing potential, while activists' ability to shift platforms (Sirivunnabood, 2020), rebuild groups (Suliman, 2020), and decentralize leadership (Jha, 2020) revealed a significant degree of adaptive resource management. Taken together, digital resources became a decisive factor in sustaining collective action despite increasing state constraints.

The organizational structure of the 2020 Thai protest movements differed from earlier waves of protest. Rather than being centered around formal organizations or charismatic leaders, the youth-led protests operated through decentralized and loosely connected networks such as *Free Youth*, the *United Front of Thammasat and Demonstration*, and *Bad Student* (Ganjanakhundee, 2021). Although several prominent activists became publicly recognizable figures, they did not occupy formal leadership positions. This deliberate avoidance of hierarchical leadership system reflected a strategic choice to remain "as flat as possible," (Jha, 2020) with leadership open and replaceable (Ganjanakhundee, 2021). From an RM perspective, the movements relied on decentralized activist networks as an important social-organizational resource (Edwards

& Gillham, 2013), which enabled flexible coordination and reduced the risks associated with centralized leadership where key actors could be arrested. At the same time, the absence of a centralized authority complicated unified goal-setting and formal negotiation with the government (Waiwitlikhit, 2020), showing that this organizational resource also had certain limitations.

Student networks and educational institutions functioned as important social-organizational resources for mobilization (Edwards & Gillham, 2013). In early 2020, dozens of campus flash mobs took place across multiple provinces, marking the first time in decades that students from traditionally conservative universities engaged in public political protest (Lertchoosakul, 2021). Universities offered not only physical gathering spaces but also opportunities to build strong student networks through which protest ideas and tactics could spread quickly. When the pandemic temporarily halted public demonstrations, activists continued to sustain the movement by using social media, expanding their networks, and raising awareness of key political issues (Ockey, 2021). These networks therefore remained important for coordination and mobilization even when protests could not take place on campuses. Beyond visible protest participation, activist networks developed under restrictive political conditions prior to 2020 also played an important role. Informal spaces such as activist houses and camps enabled coordination, knowledge sharing, and cross-regional ties among young activists (Horatanakun, 2024), creating social network resources (Edwards & Gillham, 2013) that could later support broader mobilization.

The movement also drew on substantial human resources. While university and secondary school students formed its core, protests were joined by artists, musicians, comedians, academics, office workers, former Red Shirts, and other social groups (Ganjanakhundee, 2021; Sangkhamanee, 2021). This diverse participation broadened the movement's social base and expanded its skill set. Creative performances, satire, digital design, and cultural references (McCargo, 2021; Lertchoosakul, 2022; Anamwathana & Thanapornsanguth, 2023) became important protest activities, reflecting the abilities of a generation highly familiar with digital communication and popular culture. High school activists associated with the Bad Student group, for example, organized music performances, symbolic campaigns, and satirical plays that criticized the education system (Anamwathana & Thanapornsanguth, 2023). From a resource mobilization perspective, these creative abilities represent an important human resource that strengthened the movement's capacity to communicate its demands and engage wider audiences (Edwards & Gillham, 2013).

Financial resources appear to have been more decentralized and less structured. There is limited publicly verifiable evidence of large-scale funding, and authorities signaled potential investigations into alleged financial backers (Head, 2020), which may have discouraged transparency. Available reporting suggests reliance on small-scale donations and short-term crowdfunding efforts (Tanakasempipat, 2020; Phasuk, 2020). For

example, Thai K-pop fan communities started fundraising campaigns and mobilized substantial funds within hours to purchase protective equipment such as helmets and goggles, organize deliveries to protest sites, and support legal defense organizations such as *Thai Lawyers for Human Rights*¹² (Tanakasempipat, 2020). Similarly, some youth-led groups such as Bad Student operated on minimal budgets but were able to receive swift online donations as well as non-financial support, including food, medical assistance, and organizational supplies, often provided by sympathetic adults (Phasuk, 2020). These patterns indicate a decentralized funding structure dependent on voluntary contributions rather than centralized financial sponsorship. While such an approach reduced the risk of targeted repression, it also likely constrained the movement's long-term organizational capacity.

Overall, these findings show how Thai student movements mobilized during the 2020–2021 demonstrations. They relied primarily on a decentralized organizational structure, strong student networks, digital skills, and creative symbolic forms of protest, as well as small donations from many supporters rather than formal institutions or elite support. Among these resources, digital platforms and student networks appear to have been particularly important for the rapid expansion of the protests. This structure shaped both the strengths and the limits of the mobilization, allowing flexibility and resilience while making it harder to build stable long-term organizations. These findings illustrate how several types of resources identified by resource mobilization theory, particularly human, social-organizational, cultural, and material resources, contributed to sustaining the movement, while solidarity from sympathetic individuals also provided elements of moral resources (Edwards & Gillham, 2013). At the same time, resource mobilization alone cannot fully explain the emergence and development of the protests (Piven & Cloward, 1991; Buechler, 1993), making it necessary to consider the broader political conditions in which mobilization occurred (Ruedin, 2011) as well as the social-psychological processes that shape how political issues are interpreted and framed (Chakraborty, 2024).

4.2. The role of political opportunity structures

To better understand how political conditions shaped the emergence of the protests, this section elaborates on the perspective of *political opportunity structure* (POS). While resource mobilization theory highlights the importance of organizational capacity and the availability of resources (Goodwin & Jasper, 2015), the POS perspective focuses on the relationship between social movements and their broader political environment (Ruedin, 2011). This approach emphasizes how political institutions and power relations shape opportunities for collective action (De Moor, 2016). In the Thai case, these opportunities

¹² Thai Lawyers for Human Rights is a non-profit organization that provides legal assistance to individuals prosecuted for political activities. During the 2020 protests it offered pro bono legal support to more than 90 arrested protesters (Tanakasempipat, 2020).

can be understood through both relatively stable structural conditions and more dynamic political developments (Ruedin, 2011) that shaped the timing of the 2020–2021 protests.

Stable political opportunities refer to relatively persistent structural characteristics of a political system that shape the long-term environment in which social movements operate (De Moor, 2016). In the Thai case, these stable political opportunities are shaped by the country's semi-authoritarian political system, where formal democratic institutions coexist with strong unelected actors (Connors and Pathmanand, 2021). As discussed in the theoretical section, the Thai political order is often described as a tutelary democracy in which the military and the monarchy retain significant influence over political decision-making (Mérieau, 2019). Institutional arrangements introduced after the 2014 coup, particularly the 2017 Constitution, strengthened this system by empowering unelected institutions such as the Constitutional Court and the military-appointed Senate, while limiting the capacity of elected actors to challenge the existing power structure (Ganjanakhundee, 2021; Mérieau, 2019). From the perspective of POS theory, this institutional framework contributes to a relatively closed political environment in which institutional channels for political participation remain limited (De Moor, 2016), increasing the likelihood that political grievances may be expressed through protest rather than formal participation. At the same time, civil liberties and political expression have been restricted through various legal mechanisms (The Right of Peaceful Assembly, 2021). Although freedoms of assembly and speech are formally guaranteed, their practical exercise has often been limited through legal instruments such as the lèse-majesté law, emergency decrees, and digital regulations (U.S. Department of State, 2021). These mechanisms have contributed to a political environment in which open criticism of key institutions carries significant legal and personal risks (Yeluri, 2023). Together, these structural features created a largely closed set of stable political opportunities, making it more difficult for student mobilization to expand and influence political outcomes through formal political processes.

While these structural conditions defined the broader political environment, the emergence of the 2020–2021 protests was also influenced by more dynamic political opportunities. In contrast to relatively stable structural conditions that shape the political environment over longer periods of time, dynamic opportunities refer to shorter-term political developments or events that can reshape perceptions of how open the political system is and trigger mobilization (Ruedin, 2011). One of the most significant developments was the dissolution of the *Future Forward Party* (FFP) in February 2020 by the Constitutional Court (Lertchoosakul, 2021). The party had gained strong support among younger voters during the 2019 election and was perceived as representing a more reform-oriented political alternative (Chanlett-Avery, Dolven, & Smith, 2020; Ockey, 2021). Its dissolution was therefore interpreted by many students as evidence that institutional political channels were being deliberately restricted, contributing to the perception that meaningful political change could not be achieved through these channels (Carter, 2020; International Affairs, 2024). More broadly, the emergence of FFP reflected

deeper transformations within Thai society. According to Chaitawat, one of the party's co-founders, the establishment of *Future Forward Party* was motivated by a sense that Thailand had entered a new political period¹³ following the 2016 royal succession (Laohabut & McCargo, 2024). In this context, many younger voters increasingly felt disconnected from traditional political parties and dissatisfied with the performance of the military-backed government (Anamwathana & Thanapornsanguth 2023; Seo, 2021). The inability of established political actors, including the long-dominant *Pheu Thai Party*, to effectively represent these emerging political demands created space for new political actors and helped bring a younger generation more actively into politics (Laohabut & McCargo, 2024). Within the framework of POS, these developments can be interpreted as dynamic changes (Ruedin, 2011) in the political environment that increased the perceived need for mobilization outside formal political institutions.

While the dissolution of the FFP represented an important political trigger for student mobilization, the outbreak of the COVID-19 pandemic further reshaped the political context in which these protests developed by creating additional dynamic opportunities. Economic conditions during the pandemic also intensified public dissatisfaction (Anamwathana & Thanapornsanguth, 2023). The crisis had a particularly severe impact on Thailand's tourism sector, which represents a significant portion of the national economy (Waiwitlikhit, 2020). Under lockdown regulations, tourism revenue declined dramatically in 2020, while unemployment and wage reductions affected a large portion of the workforce (Ockey, 2021; Waiwitlikhit, 2020). These economic strains that emerged during the government's pandemic response disproportionately affected younger and more vulnerable populations, many of whom were already facing uncertain employment opportunities (Auethavornpipat & Tanyag, 2021; Sombatpoonsiri, 2021; Save the Children, 2022). As a result, economic grievances increasingly overlapped with political dissatisfaction, contributing to a broader support base for the emerging student-led protest movements (Anamwathana & Thanapornsanguth, 2023). The health and economic crises also set the stage for increased public questioning of royal power. Public criticism increased as King Maha Vajiralongkorn (Rama X) spent much of the pandemic abroad in Germany while Thailand faced severe difficulties, which could be interpreted as a sign of detachment from domestic challenges (Ebbighausen, 2020; Sombatpoonsiri, 2021). This further contributed to growing dissatisfaction among politically active groups in society. The pandemic also affected political opportunities in more direct ways. In March 2020 the government declared a nationwide state of emergency, transferring extensive authority directly to the prime minister while restricting public gatherings (Ockey, 2021). While these measures initially limited the possibility of public demonstrations, the easing of restrictions in mid-2020 created a temporary window in which activists were able to organize protests and mobilize supporters (Auethavornpipat & Tanyag, 2021). From the perspective of POS, these developments illustrate how changing political conditions and

¹³ A new political phase in which, according to Chaitawat, existing elites struggled to unite society or connect diverse groups. This created space for new political actors such as the *Future Forward Party*, which helped mobilize younger voters (Laohabut & McCargo, 2024).

government responses to crisis can reshape the timing and possibilities of protest mobilization.

Despite these limited openings, the broader political opportunity structure remained largely unfavorable to the protest movements. The ruling government, led by Prime Minister Prayut Chan-o-cha, maintained strong control over state institutions and retained relative stability within its governing coalition (Sriyai, 2023). Rather than addressing protest demands, the government largely responded through legal prosecution, arrests of prominent activists, and police crackdowns aimed at suppressing mobilization (Seo, 2021; Charoenthansakul & Natee, 2023). The use of emergency powers during the COVID-19 pandemic further strengthened the state's capacity to restrict public assembly and limit the scale of protests (Auethavornpipat & Tanyag, 2021). Consequently, although dynamic political opportunities helped trigger protest mobilization, the broader political opportunity structure continued to constrain the movement's capacity to achieve larger political change. Together with the examination of governmental responses presented in earlier sections (Chapters 2.3 and 3.0) of this thesis, these findings specify how the Thai government responded to the student protest movements during the 2020–2021 demonstrations.

4.3. Key framing narratives and demands

This section analyses the key framing narratives of the Thai protest movement. Framing processes shape how social movements interpret political developments, articulate political grievances, and mobilize supporters (Goffman, 1974; Almeida, 2019). Snow and Benford (1988) distinguish three core framing tasks, namely *diagnostic framing*, which involves identifying problems and assigning responsibility, *prognostic framing*, which focuses on proposing solutions and strategies, and *motivational framing*, which provides reasons for individuals to participate in collective action. At the same time, the Thai student movement's framing efforts also involved broader processes of frame alignment, through which activists connected their messages with the experiences and concerns of wider audiences (Almeida, 2019).

In terms of *diagnostic framing*, protesters identified several interconnected problems within the Thai political system. A major concern was the continued political dominance of the military-backed government led by Prime Minister Prayuth Chan-o-cha (Ockey, 2021), as well as the institutional framework established after the 2014 military coup, particularly the 2017 Constitution, which many demonstrators viewed as obstructing democratic development in the country (Sombatpoonsiri, 2023). Protest participants also criticized the government's management of the COVID-19 pandemic and its economic consequences, arguing that the administration had failed to provide sufficient support for citizens affected by lockdowns and economic decline (Anamwathana & Thanapornsanguth, 2023; Charoenthansakul & Natee, 2023). Other issues raised by the movement included restrictions on freedom of expression, legal measures against

activists, and broader concerns about political repression (Sombatpoonsiri, 2021; Anamwathana & Thanapornsanguth, 2023). At the same time, some activists began to question the political role of the monarchy, arguing that its position within the political system should be openly debated (Prachatai, 2020). Together, these issues were framed as evidence of deeper structural problems within the Thai political system.

These grievances were often accompanied by *prognostic framing*, which focused on proposing concrete political solutions. Protest demands included the resignation of the prime minister, the dissolution of parliament, and the drafting of a new democratic constitution (Ockey, 2021; Lertchoosakul, 2021). The articulation of these demands suggests a coherent prognostic framing, which is not always common in protest movements, as participants often agree more easily on what the problem is than on how it should be addressed (Ketelaars, Walgrave & Wouters, 2014). Once these core demands were established, it also became easier for the movement to incorporate additional political issues into its broader reform agenda. As the movement's support base expanded, the scope of its demands gradually increased to include broader institutional reforms, including limitations on the political and economic role of the monarchy (Seo, 2021). In August 2020, activists from the *United Front of Thammasat and Demonstration* (UFTD) presented a ten-point manifesto calling for reforms to the monarchy, including greater transparency, constitutional accountability, and changes to the laws protecting the royal family (Chanlett-Avery, Dolven, & Smith, 2020; Lertchoosakul, 2021). Narratives surrounding the monarchy eventually became the movement's central framing theme (Sombatpoonsiri, 2023). While many protesters emphasized that they did not seek to abolish the monarchy, the proposed reforms were framed as necessary for strengthening the democratic system and preserving the monarchy by placing it above politics (Ockey, 2021), thereby presenting institutional reform as a key solution to the political problems identified by the movement.

Importantly, the framing of protest demands evolved over time as the movement expanded. During the early phase of mobilization in 2020, protest narratives primarily emphasized opposition to the military-backed government and calls for democratic reforms. As the protests gained momentum later in 2020, however, public discussions increasingly focused on the political role of the monarchy, an issue that had long been considered highly sensitive in Thai society (Ockey, 2021; Sombatpoonsiri, 2023). This shift became particularly visible after activist Anon Nampa publicly called for open discussion about monarchy reform in August 2020, contributing to a broader change in the movement's framing strategies and helping to break a long-standing taboo surrounding public discussion of the monarchy (Prachatai, 2020; Sombatpoonsiri, 2023). This development illustrates a process of *frame transformation* (Snow, Rochford, Worden & Benford, 1986), as activists challenged previously dominant interpretations of the monarchy and encouraged new ways of discussing its role in politics. Later stages of the protests also raised criticisms of the government's pandemic response and economic management, including calls for the government to provide effective COVID-19 vaccines

for the population (Anamwathana & Thanapornsanguth, 2023; Charoenthansakul & Natee, 2023). By adapting its framing to emerging political and social concerns, the Thai pro-democracy student movement was able to sustain mobilization and connect its democratic demands with issues that resonated with a wider public.

In addition to identifying problems and proposing solutions, the movement also relied on *motivational framing* to encourage participation. Motivational frames are intended to provide reasons for individuals to take part in collective action by linking broader political issues to people's values and everyday experiences (Caiani, 2023). In the Thai protests, organizers frequently emphasized values such as democracy, equality, and the idea that political power should belong to the people, presenting participation in demonstrations as a way for citizens to defend these principles (Prachatai, 2020; McCargo, 2021; Takahashi, 2022). Demonstrators often declared that "the country belongs to the people" and used the three-finger salute borrowed from *The Hunger Games* film series as a symbol of resistance against authoritarian rule¹⁴ (Sombatpoonsiri, 2021; Takahashi, 2022). Protest activities also frequently used elements of popular culture, including references to *Harry Potter*, Japanese anime, and protest music (Anamwathana & Thanapornsanguth, 2023; Prachatai, 2020). These references helped communicate political messages in a more accessible way and made the movement particularly appealing to younger participants. By connecting democratic demands with familiar cultural references and widely shared beliefs, activists were able to make political participation appear both meaningful and personally relevant, which is an important component of motivational framing (Ketelaars, 2016; Caiani, 2023).

The protests were also strongly framed around generational concerns. Many activists framed the protests as a struggle for the future of younger generations, arguing that current political decisions would have long-term consequences for their lives (France 24, 2020; Anamwathana & Thanapornsanguth, 2023). High school and university students frequently emphasized that they had the right to express their political views, as they would be the ones living with the consequences of current policies in the future (Anamwathana & Thanapornsanguth, 2023). Protest slogans such as "You have been stealing my bright future" reflected this perception of generational injustice and helped mobilize younger participants who felt excluded from government decision-making (France 24, 2020). From a framing perspective, this narrative helped present the protests as directly connected to the future of younger Thais, which in turn attracted wider support and led the movement to be seen not only as opposition to specific political leaders but also as a broader struggle over the future of democracy in Thailand.

Within the framing processes, activists also made attempts at *frame alignment*, through which they connected their grievances with broader social groups (Almeida,

¹⁴The gesture originated during the 2014 Thai coup and was later also adopted by activists in Myanmar following the 2021 military coup, where it remains in use to this day (Spring Revolution Generation, 2024; Mai, 2025).

2019). The protest movement gradually included a variety of additional issues, including education reform, LGBTQ rights, and concerns raised by earlier pro-democracy movements such as the Red Shirt movement¹⁵ (Ganjanakhundee, 2021; Ockey, 2021; Takahashi, 2022). By linking these different concerns to a shared demand for democratic change, the movement was able to broaden its support and mobilize people from different parts of Thai society. Activists also attempted to bring their message to an international audience. The hashtag #WhatsHappeningInThailand was widely used in English in order to attract international attention and bypass domestic media restrictions (Srisai, 2025). At the same time, protest speeches and public statements often highlighted stories of political repression, including the experiences of exiled activists, and individuals who had disappeared under suspicious circumstances (Prachatai, 2020). These narratives emphasized the injustice of the Thai political system and strengthened the moral urgency of the movement's demands. Such framing strategies helped maintain public attention and sustain mobilization over a longer period of time.

Taken together, these findings demonstrate that Thai student movement formulated its political demands through coherent *diagnostic*, *prognostic*, and *motivational framing* processes. Protesters identified structural problems within the Thai political system and proposed political changes such as the resignation of the prime minister, the revision of the constitution, and the dissolution of parliament (Lertchoosakul, 2021; Ockey, 2021; Seo, 2021). At the same time, the movement used narratives emphasizing democratic values and generational justice in order to mobilize broader public support (France 24, 2020; Sombatpoonsiri, 2021). By publicly raising sensitive political issues, particularly the role of the monarchy, the movement further contributed to wider public debates about democracy in Thailand (Prachatai, 2020; Ockey, 2021; Sombatpoonsiri, 2023). The broader impact of these developments on political discourse is examined in the following chapters.

4.4. Broader impacts

Building on the analysis of framing processes presented above, it is also necessary to examine how these articulated demands and narratives translated into broader political and societal outcomes. While the previous sections focused on how the movement constructed its messages, as well as on key aspects of mobilization and political opportunities, this section shifts attention to its wider impacts. It first explores the short-term effects observed during the protest period (2020–2022), before turning to the 2023 general election as a key moment for assessing the movement's longer-term political influence. This approach makes it possible to evaluate whether the movement's impact

¹⁵ The Red Shirt movement is a pro-democracy movement that emerged after the 2006 military coup which overthrew the government of Thaksin Shinawatra and advocates greater political equality and more influence for ordinary citizens (Takahashi, 2022)

remained mainly at the level of public debate or led into more concrete political developments.

4.4.1. Short-term impacts (2020-2022)

The student protests quickly produced several short-term political and societal impacts. One of the most significant developments was the growth of public debate surrounding previously sensitive political issues, particularly the political role of the monarchy. The movement's calls for reform represented a clear shift from earlier protest movements, which had generally avoided direct criticism of the monarchy (Seo, 2021). As a result, public discussion of this issue became increasingly visible in political discourse (Ockey, 2021; Sombatpoonsiri, 2023). This increased attention to the issue also contributed to political polarization and the renewal of regime-sponsored countermobilization, which had been less prominent since the democratic openings of the 1990s (Sombatpoonsiri, 2023). While the protest movement sought to challenge the existing political order, royalist groups, such as *Thai Pakdee*, organized counterprotests and online campaigns to oppose the student movement and protect the monarchy (Ganjanakhundee, 2021). On social media, pro-establishment networks promoted hashtags such as #WeLoveTheMonarchy and #ProtectTheMonarchy, which reinforced official narratives about the monarchy's central role in Thai national identity (Sombatpoonsiri, 2023). These developments together indicate that the protests did not only mobilize pro-democracy supporters but also triggered a broader conflict between reformist and royalist views within Thai political discourse.

The protests also led to reactions from political parties and state institutions. The large demonstrations on 10 August 2020, during which activists publicly presented their demands for monarchy reform, marked an important turning point (Sombatpoonsiri, 2023). Following this event, political parties increasingly engaged with the protest agenda, particularly regarding constitutional reform. Several proposals to amend the 2017 Constitution were submitted to parliament, including a popular initiative supported by more than 100,000 petitioners (Tonsakulrungruang, 2020b; McCargo, 2021). Despite this public support, most of the proposals were rejected, partly because the military-appointed Senate had little motivation to support reforms that could reduce its own influence (McCargo, 2021). Only two proposals passed the first reading in parliament, one submitted by the government and another by the opposition parties (Tonsakulrungruang, 2020b; Prachatai, 2021a). Both proposals introduced only limited changes to the constitution, including the creation of a *Constitutional Drafting Committee*, while maintaining strong protection for the monarchy (Prachatai, 2021a). The remaining bills were therefore considered conservative (Tonsakulrungruang, 2020b; McCargo, 2021) and allowed the government to appear responsive while waiting for the protests to lose momentum and delaying any substantial political change. In March 2021, parliament ultimately rejected the amendment of the constitution, which ended a year-long reform process and provoked further protests in Bangkok (Prachatai, 2021b). Later that year,

however, a separate constitutional amendment introduced significant changes to the electoral system. The reform replaced the single-ballot with a two-ballot system, allowing voters to cast one vote for a constituency candidate and another for a political party, while increasing the number of constituency seats (Phaicharoen, 2021). These changes were seen (Thanthong-Knight, 2021; Lestari, Fitrianto, Mungkornchai, Muzaqqi & Wardhani, 2024) as favoring larger political parties, including those aligned with the military-backed government. Overall, these developments show that although the protest movement succeeded in bringing constitutional reform into political debate, the existing political system limited how much change could actually be achieved.

State authorities also responded with legal measures aimed at limiting the movement. At the same time, these actions also triggered reactions from international organizations and human rights groups. Several NGOs, including *Amnesty International*, *Human Rights Watch*, *Manushya Foundation*, and *ASEAN Parliamentarians for Human Rights*, criticized the government's use of force and the application of the *lèse-majesté* law against protesters and called for the protection of fundamental rights and freedoms (Human Rights Watch, 2020b). Similarly, representatives of the *United Nations* urged Thai authorities to refrain from violence and warned that the use of criminal charges against protesters would undermine freedom of expression (Seo, 2021). In addition, the protests encouraged engagement from domestic non-governmental actors. For example, the NGO *Internet Law Reform Dialogue* (iLaw) drafted a constitutional reform proposal that reflected key demands of the protest movement, including changes to the selection of the prime minister and a reduction of the Senate's political influence¹⁶ (Chalermphanupap, 2020). Nevertheless, while such responses increased both domestic and international pressure on the government, their immediate impact remained limited, as legal actions against activists continued and the authorities showed little willingness to implement substantial reforms (Seo, 2021).

The protests also appeared to influence the behavior and public visibility of the monarch himself. Following the escalation of demonstrations in 2021, King Vajiralongkorn (Rama X) spent a longer period of time in Thailand than in previous years¹⁷ and engaged in a series of public appearances across the country, including interviews and informal meet-and-greet events with citizens, as well as more direct public interactions, such as posing for photographs, which had previously been uncommon for the king (McCargo, 2021). This shift was further characterized by a more active and highly publicized involvement in state affairs and diplomatic activities (Pattaya Mail, 2021; Nation Thailand, 2022). Such increased political engagement was often strategically televised to project an image of institutional stability and active leadership (Nation Thailand, 2022). These actions can be understood as efforts to reinforce public

¹⁶ This proposal was rejected in Parliament at the first reading in November 2020, despite receiving some support from lawmakers (Bangkok Post, 2020).

¹⁷ Prior to the protests, King Vajiralongkorn spent much of his time in Germany, particularly in Bavaria, where his son attended school (Ganjanakhundee, 2021; Reuters, 2020).

support for the monarchy and respond to the growing criticism voiced by protesters. At the same time, the king publicly expressed support for royalist groups opposing the protest movement and emphasized the importance of loyalty to the monarchy (Chanlett-Avery, Dolven, & Smith, 2020; Waiwitlikhit, 2020). However, his public statements also showed a more mixed approach. In some instances, the monarch indicated a willingness to ease tensions, referring to Thailand as a “land of compromise” and expressing equal concern for all citizens (Waiwitlikhit, 2020). This suggests that the Thai pro-democracy student movement managed to influence the behavior of the monarch himself, which is particularly significant given that King Vajiralongkorn’s (Rama X) rule has been associated with a strong emphasis on authority and the use of fear as a mechanism for maintaining political and social order, making such visible changes in his public behavior relatively uncommon (Chachavalpongpun, 2022). This is especially notable in the broader context of the Thai monarchy, where influence has traditionally been exercised more indirectly through networks and intermediaries rather than through frequent direct public engagement (Rodyim, 2024).

Beyond institutional and elite responses, the protests also had important social impacts. The movement brought together a wide range of social groups, including university and high school students, LGBTQ activists, artists, labor groups, religious communities, junior office workers, Buddhist monks, and celebrities (Alexander, 2021; Seo, 2021; Ganjanakhundee, 2021; Sombatpoonsiri, 2023). In some cases, the protests also received cautious or partial support from prominent members of the establishment. For example, former Prime Minister Anand Panyarachun expressed carefully worded support for the protesters (McCargo, 2021), while prominent conservative commentator Veera Prateepchaikul (2020) acknowledged that he personally found several of the students’ demands to be “reasonable”. Moreover, middle-class citizens and even former supporters of the 2014 coup began to express support for the movement, sometimes aligning with groups that had previously been seen as political opponents (Wilson, 2020). In addition, many adults actively supported the protests in practical ways by providing supplies, medical assistance, or protection for younger participants, while allowing student activists to remain at the forefront of the movement without attempting to take control of it (Phasuk, 2020). Cooperation between student activists and supporters of earlier pro-democracy movements, such as the Red Shirt movement, also contributed to the organization of large-scale demonstrations and further strengthened coordination across different protest networks (Takahashi, 2022). At the same time, however, the protests created tensions within Thai society, particularly between younger and older generations. Thanapornsanguth and Anamwathana (2022), based on student testimonies, show that many young activists experienced conflicts with teachers and school administrators regarding their political participation. This generational divide was also reflected more broadly within families, where disagreements over the role of the monarchy led to growing tensions (BBC, 2020). Some educational institutions attempted to restrict students’ political expression, for example by banning protest symbols such as the three-finger salute, or by denying them access to protest spaces, as illustrated by

restrictions at Thammasat University, where permission to hold a rally was refused. In certain cases, teachers also reportedly threatened to deduct grades, and there were even incidents of physical punishment, such as a teacher allegedly slapping a student for wearing a white bow to class (McCargo, 2021; Thanapornsangsuth & Anamwathana, 2022).

In conclusion, these developments demonstrate that the student protests had several immediate impacts on Thailand's political and social environment. The protests contributed to the expansion of public debates about sensitive political issues, encouraged both reformist and royalist mobilization, and triggered responses from political actors and state institutions. In this sense, the movement significantly influenced the broader political discourse in Thailand. The protests also appeared to influence the behavior and public visibility of the King Vajiralongkorn (Rama X), who increased his presence in Thailand after having spent much of his time abroad in previous years. Their impact was further evident in the education sector, where some schools and universities attempted to restrict students' political expression. More broadly, the protests contributed to increased social polarization, particularly between generations.

4.4.2. 2023 general election

The 2023 general election provides an important opportunity to assess the longer-term political impact of the 2020–2021 student protests. Electoral system changes introduced in 2021 were seen (Phaicharoen, 2021; Lestari et al, 2024) as favoring larger political parties. Nevertheless, the strong performance of the *Move Forward Party* (MFP), which won the highest number of votes and secured 151 out of 500 seats in the House of Representatives, suggests that many of the demands raised during the protests were supported by a large number of voters (Horatanakun, 2023).¹⁸ In particular, the party's reform-oriented agenda, including its proposal to not only amend the lèse-majesté law, but also to promote broader democratic and institutional reforms (Bundith, Kulachai & Kittisaknawin, 2024), reflected issues that had been previously strongly promoted by the student movement (Tonsakulrungruang, 2024). In this sense, the movement successfully managed to bring its demands into the electoral politics. The electoral outcome is also linked to the mobilization of younger voters (Losty, 2023). This group became more politically engaged and supportive of structural reforms, and as a result, played a significant role in affecting the final results (France 24, 2023; Sinpeng & Raymond, 2025). Voter participation exceeded 75%, with nearly 40 million votes cast, the highest total in Thailand's electoral history. Among them were around five million first-time voters, many of whom had previously participated in or been exposed to the protest movement (Losty, 2023). At the same time, the MFP actively targeted millennial and

¹⁸ The MFP was led by Pita Limjaroenrat, whose leadership and campaign strategy played a key role in the party's electoral success, particularly in mobilizing younger voters. His effective use of social media to engage with voters and communicate the party's vision further contributed to building a strong support base (Bundith, Kulachai & Kittisaknawin, 2024).

Generation Z voters, who together make up nearly half of the electorate, which shows that youth support played a crucial role in the election result (France 24, 2023). More broadly, the 2023 election reflected increasing polarization, especially between younger, pro-reform voters and more conservative groups within society (Sinpeng & Raymond, 2025). This divide was closely linked to the issues raised during the 2020–2021 protests, which had already exposed growing generational and ideological tensions within Thai society (BBC, 2020).

The success of the MFP can also be better understood in connection with the earlier *Future Forward Party* (FFP), from which it effectively emerged after the FFP's dissolution in 2020. The banning of the FFP had already mobilized politically active youth and contributed to the emergence of the protest movement, creating a direct link between the FFP, the protests, and the later success of the MFP (Teeratanabodee & Wasserstrom, 2024). In this sense, the MFP not only built on the support base of its predecessor but also continued to promote similar reform-oriented ideas among younger voters. These developments, together with the experience of the protests, also helped to expand political activism beyond Thailand itself. More than 115,000 overseas Thai voters became actively politically engaged, with participation rates reaching around 80%, and many expressing strong support for the MFP, often motivated by perceived injustices in the domestic political system and seeking to support democratic change from outside the country (Chachavalpongpun, 2025).

At the same time, the election also revealed persistent structural limitations within the Thai political system. Despite winning the largest share of seats, the MFP was unable to form a government due to constitutional arrangements introduced in 2016, which were designed to limit the influence of elected political parties (Horatanakun, 2023). These restrictions reduced the ability of pro-reform actors to turn electoral success into an actual political power and have been described (Singhatiraj, 2023; FIDH, 2024) as a significant obstacle to democratization in Thailand. This was further demonstrated by developments after the election. In 2024, the Constitutional Court ordered the dissolution of the MFP, arguing that its campaign to amend the lèse-majesté law constituted an attempt to overthrow the monarchy (Stiftung, 2024). The Court also imposed a ten-year ban on party executives and linked the party to the earlier 2020-2021 youth protest movement, suggesting that MFP members had supported the movement and that its reform agenda therefore posed a broader threat to the political system (Tonsakulrungruang, 2024). This association suggests that the protest movement may have indirectly influenced how state authorities perceived the party, contributing to a stricter response toward actors advocating political reform. In addition, international observation reports pointed to mixed developments. The *Asian Network for Free Elections* (ANFREL) noted improvements in accountability and transparency compared to the 2019 elections, but also highlighted ongoing structural issues, particularly the role of the unelected Senate (Freedom House, 2026). These mixed outcomes are also reflected in broader democracy indicators. Thailand's *Freedom House* score improved slightly from 29/100 in 2021 to

36/100 in 2023, but declined again to 34/100 in 2024, suggesting only limited and unstable progress in political rights and civil liberties.

All in all, these developments indicate that while the protest movement had a clear impact on electoral behavior and public debate, its ability to produce lasting institutional change remained limited, as structural features of the political system continue to constrain democratization processes in Thailand (FIDH, 2024). At the same time, the findings clarify how the student movements were reflected in political discourse. The results show that issues previously raised by the protests became more visible and politically relevant, shaping electoral competition, and political divisions within Thai society. In this sense, the 2023 election and its aftermath demonstrate both the significant influence of the student protests and the persistence of Thailand's existing political system.

5. DISCUSSION

The findings of this thesis confirm that *Social Movement Theory* (SMT), particularly its focus on *resource mobilization*, *political opportunity structures*, and *framing*, provides an effective analytical framework for examining the Thai student protests of 2020–2021. Furthermore, the successful application of these concepts also demonstrates that SMT is applicable to the broader Southeast Asian region. In line with this framework, the Thai protests emerged mainly from the interaction between digital forms of mobilization, a restrictive political environment, and effective framing strategies, rather than being driven by a single factor. This supports the argument of Bert Klandermans and Jacquelin van Stekelenburg (2009), who emphasize that social movements are best understood as the result of multiple interacting processes instead of separate factors.

From the perspective of *resource mobilization*, the results indicate a strong reliance on digital platforms as key organizational and communicative resources. This is consistent with the research of Manuel Castells (2012), who had already highlighted the growing importance of networked communication in modern social movements. Digital tools also reduce the need for centralization and charismatic leadership (Obaid, 2020), allowing participants to engage more flexibly and at different levels of commitment. The Thai case reflects this pattern, as decentralized and digitally coordinated activism with loose connections among participants enabled rapid mobilization and resilience against repression (Ganjanakhundee, 2021; Sinpeng, 2021). At the same time, however, the analysis in this thesis suggests that such forms of organization may have limited the movement's ability to develop into a more stable, long-term form, to effectively negotiate with authorities, and to achieve institutional change. This corresponds with existing critiques (Van Laer & Van Aelst, 2010; Tufekci, 2014) of digitally driven movements.

In terms of *political opportunity structures*, the findings indicate that the Thai protests emerged despite a largely closed political system. This observation aligns with the work of Sidney Tarrow (2011), a leading scholar in the field, who argues that protests often arise not only from opportunities but also from constraints within the political system. In the Thai case, the dissolution of the *Future Forward Party* (FFP) and dissatisfaction with the 2019 election acted as key triggers for mobilization, while the broader institutional system continued to limit the movement's ability to achieve political change (McCargo, 2021). This pattern of events suggests that the timing and emergence of the protests were shaped less by the structural openness of the political system and more by accumulated grievances and specific moments that changed how activists perceived their chances of influencing politics. In addition, the Thai case demonstrates that opportunities for mobilization had not been given but were gradually created through the actions of the protesters themselves. As participation increased and protests gained visibility, collective action became more accessible and legitimate, encouraging further engagement. In this sense, political opportunities can also emerge from the dynamics of the movement itself, a point also emphasized by Rohman (2023).

Framing played a particularly important role in shaping both mobilization and political discourse. The movement's framing strategies closely reflect the three core framing tasks identified by David Snow and Robert Benford (1988), namely *diagnostic*, *prognostic*, and *motivational framing*. Activists clearly identified key political problems, proposed concrete solutions such as constitutional reform, and encouraged participation by linking these issues to widely shared values such as democracy and generational justice (Prachatai, 2020; France 24, 2020; Ockey, 2021). At the same time, the Thai case demonstrates how framing can extend beyond mobilization and contribute to broader societal change. By openly questioning the role of the monarchy, the movement challenged long-standing taboos and expanded the boundaries of public discourse (Ganjanakhundee, 2021). This shift indicates that framing processes can reshape not only how issues are understood but also, to some extent, what can be publicly debated.

The results indicate that student movements played a central role in shaping the protests, as they achieved strong mobilization and significantly influenced public discourse and electoral behavior, particularly in the 2023 general election. Their impact at the institutional level, however, remained limited. These insights are consistent with the work of Edwin Amenta, Neal Caren, Elizabeth Chiarello, and Yang Su (2010), who emphasize that the success of social movements depends not only on mobilization but also on favorable political conditions. The Thai case illustrates that even highly mobilized and visible movements may struggle to achieve structural change when political institutions remain resistant. At the same time, the continuation of protest-related ideas in electoral politics, particularly through the *Move Forward Party* (MFP) and its successor, the *People's Party* (PP) (Stiftung, 2024) suggests that these demands did not disappear but instead continued within a different form of political engagement. Nevertheless, the limited re-emergence of large-scale protests following the dissolution of the MFP points to a gradual loss of momentum in protest mobilization (Teeratanabodee & Wasserstrom, 2024). Factors such as repression, legal consequences, and activist exhaustion may help explain this development, suggesting that long-term mobilization in semi-authoritarian contexts is difficult to maintain, which is consistent with research (Linz, 2000; Schedler, 2006; Geddes, Wright & Frantz, 2014) in political science.

This thesis has several limitations. First, the analysis is based solely on secondary sources, including academic literature, media reports, and NGO publications. While these sources provide valuable insights, they often rely, in this case, on a relatively limited range of previously collected data and therefore do not always fully capture the diversity of individual perspectives or the internal dynamics of the movement. Second, the study focuses on a single case, which enables a more in-depth analysis of the Thai student movement, but also makes it more difficult to generalize the findings to other contexts, especially in Southeast Asia. Consequently, its broader applicability remains limited. Finally, the use of predefined SMT categories may simplify the complexity of the movement by emphasizing certain aspects while overlooking others. As a result, some important dynamics of the movement may remain insufficiently explored.

These limitations point to several directions for further research. While few existing studies have already used interviews and other forms of direct engagement with participants (Lertchoosakul, 2021; Thanapornsangsuth & Anamwathana, 2022), further work could build on these approaches by examining groups that remain underrepresented in the literature, particularly individuals who chose not to participate in the protests. Such perspectives could provide a more comprehensive understanding of the movement's broader societal impact and political malaise. Comparative research could also examine youth-led movements in other politically constrained environments across Southeast Asia in order to explore whether similar patterns of resource mobilization, framing, and interaction with political opportunities and constraints can be observed across different cases. Further research could also examine in more detail how protest movements in the region influence political parties over time, particularly how movement demands are adopted, modified, or contested within electoral competition. In the Thai context, this could include closer attention to parties such as the MFP and PP, as well as future electoral developments, which may provide important insights into the longer-term political impact of the 2020–2021 student movements.

CONCLUSION

The 2020–2021 pro-democracy protests in Thailand represent a significant moment of youth-led political mobilization, during which both the military-backed government and long-standing political taboos were openly challenged. The aim of this thesis was to examine the role of student movements in these protests. It focused on how the movements mobilized, formulated their demands, and interacted with the political environment, while also considering the broader conditions in which these processes took place. The theoretical part introduced the key approaches of *Social Movement Theory* (SMT), while also outlining the political and social context of Thailand and providing an overview of the student movements in order to clarify their main features and significance. Building on this foundation, the analytical part applied the SMT framework to the Thai case. Using the concepts of *resource mobilization*, *political opportunity structures*, and *framing*, it explored the dynamics of the protests, the responses of state authorities, and both the short-term and longer-term political impacts of the movement, including their influence on the 2023 general election. Based on this approach, the thesis addressed the following research questions:

RQ1: *How did Thai student movements mobilize and formulate their demands during the 2020–2021 pro-democracy protests?*

The analysis showed that student movements mobilized through a combination of digital communication using platforms such as Facebook, Twitter, Telegram, and Line, decentralized coordination among participants, and the use of culturally relatable symbols and references, including the three-finger salute inspired by *The Hunger Games*, as well as *Harry Potter*, Japanese anime, and protest music, which helped communicate political messages in an accessible way and made the movement particularly appealing to younger audiences. Online platforms played a key role in enabling flexible and rapid mobilization, while also lowering barriers to participation. Hashtag campaigns, such as #FreeYouth, further supported collective action by strengthening domestic connections among participants and increasing international visibility. In addition, mobilization was supported by other resources, including the use of educational institutions as early protest sites, the diverse skill sets of participants, and small-scale donations and short-term crowdfunding efforts. The movement was also connected to transnational activist networks, such as the *Milk Tea Alliance*, which enabled the exchange of protest strategies and contributed to more effective and longer-term mobilization.

In formulating their demands, activists sought to connect their grievances with broader social groups and gradually included additional issues into the movement's agenda. By adapting their framing strategies to emerging political and social concerns, they were able to maintain engagement and appeal to a wider public. At the same time, the movements formulated their demands through a clear lens of *diagnostic*, *prognostic*, and *motivational framing* processes, which is not always common in protest movements

(Ketelaars, Walgrave & Wouters, 2014). Protesters identified structural problems within the political system, proposed concrete political reforms, and connected their demands to broader values such as democracy, equality, and generational justice. Over time, these demands expanded to include highly sensitive issues, particularly the role of the monarchy, which marked a significant shift in Thai political discourse. Through these processes, student movements acted as crucial drivers of both mobilization and agenda-setting within the protests.

RQ2: What were the governmental responses to these movements?

The findings of this thesis showed that the Thai government responded to the student movements primarily through legal and repressive measures rather than political reforms. These responses included the use of emergency powers, legal prosecution and arrests of activists under laws such as the *lèse-majesté* and the Computer Crime Act, as well as restrictions on public assembly. Authorities also put pressure on educational institutions to limit student participation in protests. In addition, force was used to disperse protests, including water cannons, tear gas, and rubber bullets. Governmental responses extended to the digital space, including surveillance of online activity, warnings against sharing protest-related content, and attempts to restrict access to protest groups on platforms such as Facebook and Telegram. Furthermore, while the government engaged in limited discussions on constitutional reform, these initiatives did not result in any significant institutional change and as a result failed to address the core demands of the protest movements. Overall, the governmental response reflected the broader characteristics of Thailand's political system, in which unelected institutions retain significant influence and limit the potential for political change.

RQ3: How were the student movements reflected in political discourse?

The evidence exposed that the student movements had a significant impact on political discourse in Thailand. The protests contributed to the expansion of public debate, particularly by challenging long-standing taboos surrounding the monarchy and by introducing new narratives centered on democratic reform and generational inequality. At the same time, the movement gained support from a variety of social groups, including prominent public figures and parts of the middle class, which contributed to the wider spread and normalization of its demands within political discourse. These developments also led to increased political polarization, particularly between younger, pro-reform groups and more conservative parts of society, as well as to the emergence of countermobilization from royalist groups. In the longer term, the issues raised by the protest movements became more visible in electoral politics, particularly during the 2023 general election, where pro-reform actors gained substantial support, with their political agendas partially reflecting the demands previously articulated by the student movements. The protests also contributed to bringing constitutional reform into formal

political debate, although proposed amendments were ultimately rejected, it nonetheless made the issue more visible and politically contested.

The findings of this thesis showed that student movements played a complex role in Thailand's pro-democracy protests. They acted as key mobilizing actors, shaped the dynamics of the protests, and significantly influenced public discourse, while also contributing to the translation of protest demands into electoral politics. Although their ability to achieve immediate institutional change remained limited, they helped maintain momentum around key political issues and encouraged continued political participation, particularly among younger generations. These findings suggest that even in constrained political environments, student-led movements can have a long-term impact by reshaping narratives and expanding the boundaries of what is politically feasible.

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